

FADING COLOUR

India's green initiative goes grey

CAG flags major lapses in the National Mission for a Green India, including inadequate funds and failure to meet targets

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India's lunar future with NASA's Moon Base

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Iran fires back at Trump's Hormuz claim

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Padikkal's knock puts India in control

SPORT » PAGE 15



Utilise skills for nation-building, CM advises youth

NEW DELHI  
Chief Minister Rekha Gupta urged Delhi's youth not to limit their talent and capabilities to social media but to utilise their skills for innovation, employment creation and nation-building. » Page 2

Help build Viksit Delhi, L-G tells city residents

NEW DELHI  
Delhi Lieutenant-Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Saturday paid tribute to freedom fighters and nation-builders and called on the city residents to help build a 'Viksit Delhi'. » Page 2

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PM takes note of Gen Z anxieties, warns against 'intellectual Naxals'

Prime Minister Modi, addressing the nation on Independence Day, highlights India's economic and security concerns; he announces AI skilling for more than one crore youth, competitive examination coaching, and talent hunt for 2036 Olympics

Nistula Hebbar  
NEW DELHI

Addressing the nation from the ramparts of Red Fort on the 80th Independence Day of India, just days after massive youth protests rocked the capital, Prime Minister Narendra Modi stressed a seven-point economic reform plan and an outreach to Gen Z youth, promising AI skilling programmes and free online coaching, in an attempt to tackle post-globalisation anxieties. He also warned the country about the threat of "dimagi Naxals" – intellectual or ideological Naxals – in society, even after the eradication of armed left-wing extremism.

At the first Independence Day that saw *Vande*



Reaching out: PM Narendra Modi meets schoolchildren during the Independence Day celebrations at the Red Fort. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

*Mataram* preceding the National Anthem, the Prime Minister directly addressed challenges facing the youth, from employment worries to the incursion of Artificial Intelligence in everyday life. More than one crore youth will be provided AI skills in a "mission mode" drive over the

coming year, Mr. Modi said. India's digital public infrastructure will be used to provide free online coaching to students wishing to take various competitive exams, and there will be a nationwide sports talent hunt among children between five and 15 years of age ahead of the 2036

CJI expresses confidence in young lawyers

NEW DELHI  
Making his Independence Day address at the Supreme Court on Saturday, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant highlighted the "remarkable resilience" of youth and said that the "Bar and Bench remain committed to the growth" of young law graduates. » PAGE 7

BJP seeks Cong's apology in row on National Song

NEW DELHI  
The rendition of the full six stanzas of *Vande Mataram* at the Congress's headquarters has triggered a controversy with the BJP seeking an apology from the Opposition party after accusing its leader Sonia Gandhi of trying to stop the song. » PAGE 8

Olympic Games, he added. This acknowledgement of Gen Z anxieties that spilled over into the recent Jantar Mantar protests was, however, spiked by a warning about "intellectual Naxals", who, Mr. Modi said, should be identified and isolated. We have succeeded in eliminating

armed Naxalites from the forests and freeing the country from that grave threat, but these *dimagi* Naxalites are waiting for opportunities," he said.

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BCI chairperson issues apology to law students

Ishita Mishra  
NEW DELHI

Days after the Bar Council of India (BCI) tried to prevent NALSAR students from enrolling with State Bar Councils before a backlash forced it to recant, BCI chairperson Manan Kumar Mishra on Saturday apologised to law students for any hurt caused by his words or communications.

In a three-page letter issued on Independence Day, Mr. Mishra, who is also a senior advocate and BJP MP, said he regretted and apologised for any of his statements or directives that may have hurt students. "If anything connected with the present controversy, any of my words, or letter, has hurt the feelings of our law students, I sincerely regret and apologise for the same," he said.

The BCI chairperson did not name any particular institution or directly identify



Manan Kumar Mishra

the controversy in his letter. He emphasised that law students are capable of forming their own views and should not be subjected to pressure.

Describing convocation ceremonies as important milestones in the lives of graduating students, Mr. Mishra said the choice of whether to attend must rest entirely with them.

The controversy was triggered by NALSAR students who did not want the Chief Justice of India (CJI) to be the chief guest at the convocation. The BCI had then sought to penalise students for their "campaign" against the CJI.

Farmers, police clash in Haryana during protest against Independence Day event

The Hindu Bureau  
GURUGRAM

Six Haryana Police personnel, including Hansi Superintendent of Police (SP) Vinod Kumar, and a number of protesters were injured on Saturday after the police clashed with members of farmer unions and khap panchayats who were marching towards the venue of an Independence Day programme in Hansi. Both the police and protesters reportedly engaged in stone-pelting during the clashes.

Over a dozen farmer leaders and around 150 unidentified persons have been booked on charges including attempt to murder, rioting, unlawful assembly, subversive activities,



Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini during the Independence Day event in Hisar on Saturday, which the protesters planned to 'disrupt'. PTI

and voluntarily causing hurt to a public servant. Several farmer leaders were taken into preventive detention earlier in the day.

The clashes broke out near Sisai village when a group of farmers, including women, attempted to proceed towards the venue where Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini was scheduled to hoist the National Flag to mark Independence Day.

The protesters had earlier announced plans to

disrupt the programme, demanding the arrest of the prime accused in the August 4 murder of a dairy operative, Jeevan Kundu, in Hisar.

The Hansi SP told journalists that a call was issued 10 to 12 days ago to disrupt the programme and alleged that protesters pelted stones at police personnel and attempted to run them over using tractors.

Responding to a viral video purportedly showing him throwing stones as well, Mr. Kumar said that police personnel had also resorted to stone-pelting to disperse the crowd and keep protesters away.

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Blowing in the wind



Soaring shapes: Various types of kites fill the sky in Mamallapuram on Saturday as people gather for the 5th Tamil Nadu International Kite Festival. The event showcased a stunning array of kites from India, Thailand, Vietnam, Singapore, Malaysia, and Indonesia. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

Five killed amid heavy rainfall in Arunachal

Rahul Karmakar  
GUWAHATI

At least five people were killed and several others, Army personnel among them, were reported missing in separate incidents across rain-battered Arunachal Pradesh over the last three days.

Four workers were buried under debris when a landslide occurred at the Keojaring-Byaching road construction site near Naho in Upper Subansiri district on Friday, while a woman was confirmed dead and three others reported missing when a vehicle fell off the road into Lohit river at Sarti in Anjaw district on Thursday.

A flash flood and land-

Several reported missing in the rain-battered State, including troops from an Army camp

slide triggered by heavy rainfall on Friday washed away some structures of an Army camp in Pasu Pani area of Dibang Valley district's Anini.

The Army did not specify how many soldiers were swept away after the landslide, but district officials said at least five were missing since the incident occurred. One of them is a Havildar.

CONTINUED ON  
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Body of eighth worker recovered from flooded Chamoli tunnel; two still missing

Press Trust of India  
CHAMOLI (UTTARAKHAND)

Rescuers on Saturday found one more body inside a tunnel under construction inundated with water two days ago here, leading to the death of seven workers, with the clock ticking for the couple of workers still inside.

Twenty-two people were trapped inside the 3-km tunnel when the water rushed in around 7 p.m. on Thursday, according to District Disaster Management Officer N.K. Joshi.

The incident occurred at the Tehri Hydro Development Corporation's (THDC) Vishnugad-Pipalkoti hydroelectric project in Mayapur (Pipalkoti),



An ambulance leaves after the recovery of one body during a rescue operation at Pipalkoti in Chamoli district on Saturday. PTI

when landslides and subsidence caused debris and water to fill half of the tunnel.

Seven persons died over Thursday and Friday.

On Saturday, Chamoli

Additional District Magistrate Vivek Prakash said one more body was recovered during the rescue operation. Rescue teams are draining the water from the tunnel through

suction pumps, and desperately trying to reach the two workers, officials said.

On Friday, Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhama visited Pipalkoti and reviewed the rescue operations.

The deceased were identified as Pradeep Singh Pawar of Tehri, Mukesh of Chamoli, Durlabh Sharma of Bihar, Vijay Hansda and Jitendra Kumar of Jharkhand, and Lokeshwar and Bhuneshwar of Chhattisgarh.

The three missing till Friday were Lucas Topno from Jharkhand and Chetan Poyam and Devnath from Chhattisgarh.

The identity of the latest casualty was not yet revealed.

Govt. brings scheme to disclose foreign assets

Press Trust of India  
NEW DELHI

The Income Tax Department on Saturday notified a new voluntary disclosure scheme allowing small taxpayers to declare certain undisclosed foreign assets and income by paying an effective 60% tax, as the government seeks to bring overseas holdings into the tax net without exposing eligible individuals to further penalties or prosecution.

The Foreign Assets of Small Taxpayers-Disclosure Scheme (FAST-DS), announced in the Union Budget this year, will take effect from Sunday, with online declarations open until December 31, the

Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) said.

The scheme is aimed at taxpayers such as students, young professionals, technology employees, and relocated non-resident Indians who may have failed to disclose eligible foreign assets or income.

Under the rules, taxpayers will pay a 30% tax on the value of the declared undisclosed foreign asset or income, plus an additional amount equal to the tax, effectively taking the levy to 60%.

The fair market value of the assets will be determined as of March 31, 2026, the CBDT said.

CONTINUED ON  
» PAGE 7





Visitors at Kartavya Path on Saturday. ANI

## First-time visitors to Red Fort leave with memories of lifetime

**Suruchi Kumari**  
NEW DELHI

Thousands of people walked to the Red Fort early on Saturday morning to celebrate India's 80th Independence Day at the historic venue. For many, including families travelling long distances, the morning was less about the speeches and more about witnessing the historic ceremony in person.

Karuna and Sandeep, in their 30s, travelled from Karnataka with their children, Sayesh, 7, and Avesh, 5, to attend the celebrations. For Ms. Karuna, watching the event from Red Fort was unforgettable. "This is my first time attending the Independence Day celebrations. I have goosebumps," she said as Prime Minister Narendra Modi began his address.

For Lalita Pal, the effort to see Mr. Modi in person paid off. "We have travelled a long way, and what he said about children and

their future was encouraging. Seeing the Tricolour made the whole place feel very patriotic," she said, noting that despite the humid morning proving difficult for her young son, the family considered it worthwhile.

The celebrations also drew people who were unaware that entry required passes from the Defence Ministry portal, leaving queues stretching into the morning heat outside the Red Fort metro station. As seats in the allotted areas filled and entry gates closed, some visitors were left waiting outside. Among them was Anita Devi, in her early 30s, who travelled from Bawana on a bus with her husband and son. Dressed in a green sari, she had not known a pass was required but decided to view the decorated fort from outside. "Even if I'm outside, hearing the national anthem gives me pride," she said.

(With inputs from Shrimansi Kaushik)

# Look beyond social media, focus on nation-building, CM advises youth on I-Day

India is fighting a 'two-and-a-half-front war', which includes 'a front within', Gupta says; Delhi to be developed as an 'active, attentive, attractive' city, become a model for other States, she adds

**The Hindu Bureau**  
NEW DELHI

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta urged Delhi's youth not to limit their talent and capabilities to social media but to utilise their skills for innovation, job creation and nation-building.

Delivering the Independence Day address at Chhatrasal Stadium, Ms. Gupta said young people must stay wary of the influence of "urban Naxals", adding that the country is fighting a "two-and-a-half-front war", which includes "a front within".

### 'Create start-ups'

"India's new generation understands technology, is connected to the world and is sensitive to issues such as mental health, climate change, gender equality, innovation and social justice. They need to turn their ideas into start-ups, creativity into innovation, questions into research, sensitivity into service and talent into nation-building," said the CM. She added that these tasks must be carried out while holding on to one's identity as an Indian.

"A developed Delhi is one that is modern while remaining connected to its roots," she said.



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta during the I-Day event at Chhatrasal Stadium. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Presenting a "report card" of her government's achievements since coming to power in February last year, Ms. Gupta said with the Central government's assistance, the Capital will become a role model for other States.

### 'Separate department'

"A separate department for Delhi's development has been created under the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs. The Reserve Bank of India has been appointed as the official banker to facilitate funds for development in Delhi. The national capital will be developed as an 'ac-

tive, attentive and attractive' city," she said.

Reiterating the pledge to make Delhi clean and green, Ms. Gupta said her government's priority is to spruce up the city during its five-year term.

"This encompasses not just physical roadside garbage, but also the associated corruption, red tape, archaic and complex systems, pollution and the massive mounds of accumulated waste," she said.

The CM added that Delhi should be viewed not only through its problems but also through its opportunities.

Regarding the city's air

pollution challenge, Ms. Gupta said a drive is under way to plant 70 lakh trees and saplings across Delhi. Of these, more than 63 lakh saplings have already been planted, she said.

"The garbage mounds have been reduced. The government is working on fulfilling its resolve to remove the garbage mountains from Delhi," Ms. Gupta said.

She added that rejuvenating the Yamuna is a top policy priority and expressed hope that the "speed and strength of the double-engine government will set new benchmarks in development".



L-G Taranjit Singh Sandhu with visitors at an I-Day event at Lok Niwas on Saturday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

## L-G Sandhu calls for collective effort to build Viksit Delhi

**The Hindu Bureau**  
NEW DELHI

Lieutenant-Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Saturday paid tribute to freedom fighters and nation-builders and called on the city residents to help build a 'Viksit' (developed) Delhi'.

Addressing an event after hoisting the national flag at Lok Niwas on Saturday, Mr. Sandhu stressed the need for seamless coordination among the Centre, the Delhi government, civic bodies, neighbouring States and citizens. "We need to have a collective resolve to make Delhi a premier global capital that balances its heritage with modernity, ensuring that every citizen feels safe, valued and empowered," he said.

The L-G added, "Residents must keep their neighbourhoods clean, protect public spaces and fulfil their fundamental duties as government efforts

alone cannot ensure that public spaces remain well maintained."

### 'Sacred duty'

Reflecting on his association with the city, Mr. Sandhu said for him, service to Delhi, where he has worked for 50 years, is not merely an administrative duty but a "sacred responsibility".

"Every district, street and neighbourhood of Delhi tells its own story, and the Capital holds immense potential. It is the collective responsibility of the administration to provide convenience, dignity and well-being for every citizen," he said.

The L-G said cleaning the Yamuna, tackling air pollution, ensuring housing, affordable health care, safety and security for everyone – particularly women and children, traffic management, and the rejuvenation of Delhi's heritage are among the Capital's priorities.



Security personnel at Red Fort on Saturday. ANI

## Over 25K personnel kept watch at venue

**The Hindu Bureau**  
NEW DELHI

Red Fort and its surrounding areas were under extensive security cover on Saturday, with over 25,000 security personnel, including the National Security Guard and rapid response teams, deployed along with more than 1,000 AI-enabled CCTV cameras.

A separate team of security personnel monitored live footage.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (North) Raja Banthia said the security plan involved multiple layers of screening, in addition to a dedicated anti-terror response mechanism. "Advance liaison, mock drills and other measures were carried out to ensure coordination among agencies," he told mediapersons.

Visitors were not allowed to carry any item except their phones and passes. At the Lal Quila metro station, security personnel scanned belongings and seized eatables, coins, remote-control car keys, umbrellas, power banks and handbags, forcing many visitors to leave their belongings behind.

## What freedom means: at Red Fort, people speak about hope, unease, equality, pride

**Suruchi Kumari**  
NEW DELHI

The Tricolour had gone up over the Red Fort, and the crowds had begun to thin. For Delhi's citizens gathered to mark 80 years of Independence, the meaning of freedom lay far beyond history books.

For some, progress was visible in better infrastructure and technology.

For others, it was more intimate: the freedom to walk home without fear, speak openly or live without discrimination. And for some, eight decades after the British left, the question was whether the nation had come far enough for everyone to feel truly free.

Tanya Bahadur and Shikha Kumari, both 19-year-old Delhi University students, spoke about student protests, online trolling, and the unease of speaking out.

"I have only read about



Old Delhi residents flying kites on Saturday afternoon. ANI

people fighting the British. I have never seen that kind of struggle. But we have seen students protesting and girls being trolled online. So I think there are still things we have to fight for before we can say that we are completely free," Ms. Bahadur said.

Her friend said she had hoped that Prime Minister Narendra Modi would address recent protests. "The things we need to fight now are inside the country – corruption, inequality and whether everyone gets a fair chance. That is the

freedom we still have to work towards," said Ms. Kumari.

A few metres away, Venkatesh Sinha, who is in his 90s, watched the celebrations from a wheelchair, along with his daughter.

### 'Freedom from riots'

"Economically, we are better off than before. But

when I look at the poor, I wonder how much they have really moved up," he said. He hoped the next generation would cherish the value of freedom, adding, "I hope there are no

more riots."

Mr. Sinha attended the event in memory of his late wife. After her death a decade ago, he stopped coming. "She used to come here every year. She was very patriotic," he said, adding, "I came today because I don't know if I will be able to come again."

For Aliza Khan, 26, who attended with her husband, freedom meant living without constantly thinking about identity.

"We all know how things have changed. There is more hatred in society. But we chose to come here today because it is our country, for which my grandfather sacrificed his life. It is equally ours," said Ms. Khan.

Bablu, a waste-picker, said, "The nation has progressed, but our lives are still difficult. For us, freedom would mean not having to worry about whether there will be work or enough money at home."

## Children now fighting for rights; this is true freedom, says Kejriwal

**The Hindu Bureau**  
NEW DELHI

Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) national convener Arvind Kejriwal on Saturday lauded the courage of Gen Z and Gen Alpha for questioning the government and raising their voices for their rights and basic facilities. "The two generations have made the 80th year of Independence special by refusing to remain silent," he said in a video message uploaded on various social media platforms.

The former Delhi Chief Minister said children across the country have begun demanding basic facilities in their schools, including teachers, desks, clean drinking water and toilets. "Our children have now learnt to fight for their rights. This is what true freedom is," Mr. Kejriwal said.

He added that news from across the country about young children tak-



News from across the country about young children taking to the streets to seek accountability is an encouraging sign

**ARVIND KEJRIWAL**  
AAP chief, former Delhi CM

ing to the streets to seek accountability is an encouraging sign.

The AAP chief said that in Hamirpur, children have started protesting to get the road in front of their school built, and a similar fight is under way in Dehradun. In Barmer, he said, children are agitating for teachers.

Speaking about the importance of education, Mr. Kejriwal said that even after 80 years of Independence, the country's government schools remain in extremely poor condition. He added that students from disadvantaged

backgrounds are forced to attend them because they cannot afford private education.

"There are no toilets, no drinking water and no teachers in schools. No education is being imparted, and the children are left with no future. We have accepted that government schools are simply supposed to be like this, but that is not how it should be. If we do not raise our voices, how will things change?" he said.

Speaking about the change his government made in Delhi, the former CM said there was a "complete transformation" of government schools in the national capital and his party has been doing the same in Punjab as well.

"Go and see the state of government schools in Delhi and Punjab. Their students are now appearing for NEET and JEE and becoming engineers and doctors," Mr. Kejriwal said.

## PM's pitch to youth earns praise but not all convinced

**Shrimansi Kaushik**  
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's youth-oriented announcements, including AI skilling and free online coaching, at the Independence Day celebrations at Red Fort on Saturday drew praise from many young attendees.

Chennai residents Prabhakaran and Rudreshwar, who are part of a micro-chip fabrication project supported by the NITI Aayog, praised the push to include young people in science and technology. "The announcement about the government providing AI training to students is



If everything in the country is so good, why do people like me from marginalised sections struggle for education and jobs

**SACHIN**  
Job aspirant-turned-vendor

appreciable. It will help the growth of AI-based products and create a talent pool of skilled people needed to bring about an AI revolution in the tech industry," said Mr. Prabhakaran. Both were in the Capital for their project and were first-time attendees at the Independence Day celebrations at Red Fort.

Regarding the PM's speech, Mr. Rudreshwar said, "It would have been easier if other visitors also had access to the audio equipment provided to foreign dignitaries for translation of the speech."

Some also viewed Mr. Modi's announcements against the backdrop of the youth-led protest at Jantar Mantar last month.

### 'Paper leaks happen'

Seema Chaudhary, who attended the event for the first time with her two children, lauded the PM's announcements.

Referring to the agitation over the NEET paper

leak, she said young people should rise above such issues and focus on building their lives.

"The youth should rise above paper leaks and focus on doing well in life. Paper leaks happen in every government's tenure. Students have to work hard even if it means appearing for the exams multiple times or choosing a different path in life," said Ms. Chaudhary, adding, "I would advise my children the same."

However, not everyone shared her views.

Outside the venue, Sachin stood with vials of saffron, white and green, ready to paint visitors' faces in

the Tricolour for a small fee. "I have appeared for police and clerical-level job exams. But I couldn't succeed, so I turned to vegetable vending. If everything in the country is so good, why do people like me from marginalised sections struggle for education and jobs?" he said.

Mr. Sachin, a Dalit, blamed the "bureaucracy's stranglehold" over the employment and education sectors for the struggle of those from disadvantaged backgrounds. Regarding the announcements on free online coaching, he said, "It would help only if the scheme's benefits actually reach the masses."

## Speaker, DU V-C lead I-Day celebrations in city

**Press Trust of India**  
DELHI

Several high-ranking officials and dignitaries in Delhi marked Independence Day at their respective offices and institutions on Saturday.

Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta hoisted the national flag at his official residence and paid homage to the freedom fighters and national heroes whose sacrifices paved the way for India's freedom, a release from his office stated.

The Tricolour was also unfurled at Delhi Police headquarters, with senior

officers calling upon the force to uphold the values of freedom, justice, equality and dignity.

Special Commissioner of Police Rajesh Khurana hoisted the national flag and said the occasion was a reminder of the struggle and sacrifices made during the freedom movement.

At an Independence Day event in Delhi University, Vice-Chancellor Yogesh Singh said nations become great not merely by remembering their glory but also by remembering the pain they have endured to ensure such tragedies are never repeated.



Probe firm's  
water discharge  
into river:  
Odisha govt.

Press Trust of India  
BHUBANESWAR

The Odisha government on Saturday ordered a probe into the alleged discharge of excess water by a private power generation company into the Baitarani river without informing the authorities amid floods in Keonjhar district.

Revenue and Disaster Management Minister Suresh Pujari said he had directed the District Collector to investigate the matter and take action.

|                  |       |       |       |
|------------------|-------|-------|-------|
| ☀️ Timings       |       |       |       |
| DELHI            |       |       |       |
| SUNDAY, AUG. 16  |       |       |       |
| ☀️ RISE          | 05:51 | 🌅 SET | 19:00 |
| ☀️ RISE          | 09:19 | 🌅 SET | 21:06 |
| MONDAY, AUG. 17  |       |       |       |
| ☀️ RISE          | 05:52 | 🌅 SET | 18:59 |
| ☀️ RISE          | 10:17 | 🌅 SET | 21:38 |
| TUESDAY, AUG. 18 |       |       |       |
| ☀️ RISE          | 05:52 | 🌅 SET | 18:58 |
| ☀️ RISE          | 11:16 | 🌅 SET | 22:11 |

|               |     |     |
|---------------|-----|-----|
| Delhi Weather | max | min |
| Delhi City    | 35  | 26  |
| Safdarjang    | 35  | 26  |
| Palam         | 34  | 24  |

Delhi Palam Today  
33°C The weather will be warm. Spell of light rain and thundershower with gusty winds to occur. Night will be comfortable.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow  
34°C The weather will be warm. Spell of light rain and thundershower to occur. Night will be comfortable.

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THE HINDU  
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Telangana Deputy CM M. Bhatti Vikramarka distributing Digital Smart Ration Cards to beneficiaries in Khammam on Saturday. THE HINDU

## Govt. committed to ensuring welfare of poor: Vikramarka

The Hindu Bureau  
HYDERABAD

Telangana Deputy Chief Minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka on Saturday said the Congress government is working with the objective of providing fine-quality rice to the poor and ensuring that no poor family went hungry.

Telangana has around 1.15 crore families, of which 1,06,28,092 families have ration cards. The government is providing six kg of fine-quality rice per person every month to 3,42,57,109 beneficiaries through the ration cards, he said at a programme organised in Khammam to distribute

Digital Smart Ration Cards on the occasion of Independence Day.

He claimed that no other State was implementing such a massive programme. People had faced difficulties in obtaining ration cards during the previous BRS regime, and fine-quality rice was not distributed then, he said.

Mr. Vikramarka said the Congress government under the leadership of Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy has sanctioned new ration cards to every eligible poor family in the State. In Khammam district, 62,158 new ration cards have been sanctioned in addition to the existing 4,73,275 cards.

## Rahul meets parents of Ankita Bhandari, says govt. 'protecting VIP'

Four years have passed since 19-year-old was killed at Uttarakhand resort but even today the family is waiting for justice, says Congress leader

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Saturday targeted the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) over the 2022 Ankita Bhandari murder case, in which a 19-year-old receptionist of an Uttarakhand resort was killed allegedly for resisting demands of a "VIP" guest, and said the ruling party has a "warped mentality" of protecting criminals.

In a social media statement, Mr. Gandhi said he met Ankita's parents two days earlier and that four years have passed since the murder, but even today the family is waiting for justice.

"Ankita, just 19 years old, was a receptionist at the Vanantara Resort where she was murdered by being drowned in the Chilla canal after resisting the shameful demands of a 'VIP' guest," he posted. Maintaining that the post-



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi with Ankita Bhandari's parents. ANI

mortem report confirmed evidence of violence and drowning, he said Ankita's room at the resort was demolished before any kind of investigation could take place, which is suspicious in itself.

"The most shameful aspect of this tragic case is that the State government itself continues to protect that VIP to this day. Why? Because he is a prominent leader of the BJP-RSS. This is the BJP's warped mentality - protecting rapists and criminals, providing them

political cover, even welcoming convicted rapists with garlands. The most repulsive people in the world are those who defend rapists, and the BJP is full of such individuals," the Congress leader said.

He added that the country cannot move forward until this inhuman mentality that treats women as objects for men's use is eradicated. "India will move forward only when India's women move forward - with respect, safety, equality, and justice," he said.

## Akhilesh warns party leaders against making unbridled statements

Mayank Kumar  
LUCKNOW

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav on Saturday cautioned party leaders against making statements that could hand the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) a political advantage. "No statement should be made that the BJP can exploit. We will print a pamphlet for every leader, from small to big, stating that they must speak only from this. Don't speak otherwise," said Mr. Yadav, addressing an Independence Day event at the State party headquarters.

Mr. Yadav was reacting to senior party leader Shivpal Singh Yadav's statement that Azam Khan would be made the State's Home Minister if SP comes to power in 2027, while accusing the government of subjecting the jailed leader to "injustice". Mr. Shivpal had made the statement after visiting Mr. Khan in jail.

Criticism by CM

The statement drew criticisms from Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, who alleged that the SP intended to trigger riots in Uttar



SP chief Akhilesh Yadav during the 80th Independence Day celebrations at the party office in Lucknow on Saturday. PTI

Pradesh.

"The Samajwadi Party is standing behind a person who built a university [Jauhar University in Rampur] after an individual [Mohammad Ali Jauhar] who opposed the country's Independence. They are saying if their party comes to power, they will make him the Home Minister," said Mr. Adityanath, without naming Mr. Shivpal or Mr. Khan.

He added, "Just look at their thinking. This means they want to again trigger riots in Uttar Pradesh."

## 'Attack on Badal a well-planned conspiracy'

Press Trust of India  
CHANDIGARH

Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) MP Harsimrat Kaur Badal on Saturday termed the attack on her husband and party chief Sukhbir Singh Badal a "well-planned political conspiracy" and said

whoever was behind it could not be called a Sikh.

Mr. Badal sustained injuries to his right hand in a 'kirpan' (ceremonial dagger) attack by a member of the Nihang order inside a gurdwara on the outskirts of Maharashtra's Nanded town on Thursday. The at-

tacker was later arrested.

Addressing a conference organised in memory of Karnail Singh Isru of the Goa Liberation Movement at Isru village in Punjab's Khanna, Ms. Badal turned emotional while recounting the attack on her husband.

"This second attack on Sukhbir ji in two years is part of a well-planned political conspiracy, hatched since 2015, to disrupt peace in Punjab," she claimed.

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» PAGE 6

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## उद्घाटन कार्यक्रम



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माननीय पूर्व उपराष्ट्रपति



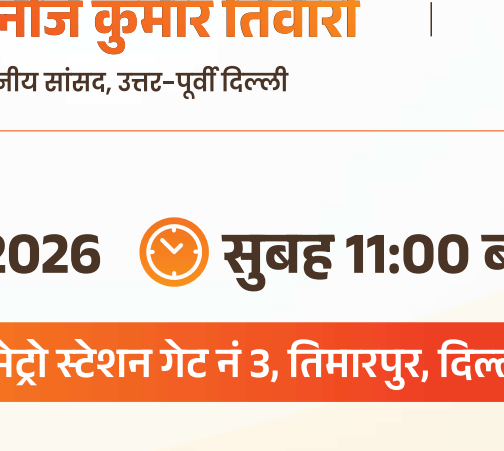
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**रेखा गुप्ता**  
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

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INBRIEF



‘Explain why 2023 women’s quota Act not implemented’

Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Sanjay Raut on Saturday said Prime Minister Narendra Modi should answer why the Women’s Reservation Act passed by Parliament in 2023 has not been implemented yet. Reacting to the Prime Minister’s Independence Day speech, Mr. Raut also said that those who are above 75 should hand over power to the youth. Speaking from the ramparts of the Red Fort, Mr. Modi called for setting aside political wrangling to ensure implementation of 33% reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies. “Women’s reservation has been passed in 2023. I urge the PM to implement it, and also answer why he did not implement it (so far),” Mr. Raut said. PTI

3 minor sisters electrocuted to death in Rajasthan’s Baran

Three minor sisters from a tribal family died due to electrocution on Saturday after they accidentally came into contact with an air cooler in a hut located in a field in Fatehpur village, Baran, Rajasthan, police said. The tragic event occurred around 7.30 a.m. in Fatehpur village. The victims were identified as Saloni, 7, Avantika, 5, and Sandhya, 2, daughters of Madanlal Sahariya. PTI

Police use water cannons to foil Hawara supporters’ march to Governor residence

Press Trust of India  
CHANDIGARH

Chandigarh police on Saturday used tear gas shells and water cannons to disperse protesters who tried to breach barricades during a march towards Punjab Governor Gulab Chand Kataria’s residence, seeking the release of Sikh prisoners, including Jagtar Singh Hawara, who is serving a life sentence for the assassination of then Punjab Chief Minister Beant Singh in 1995.

Some protesters attempted to remove barricades and barbed wire and some others tried to pull them down using a tractor as they attempted to proceed towards the residence of the Governor at the Lok Bhavan in Chandigarh. Police fired several rounds of tear gas and used water cannons to disperse them, amid the tense situation. Police also dropped tear-gas shells on the protesters by deploying a drone.



Protesters facing tear gas as police block their march towards the Punjab Governor’s house, in Chandigarh on Saturday. PTI

Meanwhile, the Qaumi Insaaf Morcha gave a call for ‘Punjab Bandh’ on August 21 to press for the release of Sikh prisoners and urged people to support the shutdown.

Shiromani Akali Dal (Amritsar) president Simranjit Singh Mann was de-

tained by Chandigarh police when he, along with two more persons, was trying to reach the residence of the Governor.

Border tense

Tight security arrangements had been put in place at the Chandigarh-Mohali borders to prevent the protesters from reaching the Lok Bhavan. Police erected multi-layer barricades topped with barbed wire and deployed anti-riot vehicles and heavy force, including Rapid Action Force personnel. All border points were sealed, while tipper trucks were also stationed at several points as part of the security arrangements.

SPOTLIGHT

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit

Eight-year-old Anu Koreti’s eyes twinkled as she raved about the performances put together to celebrate World Tribal Day on August 9. She clapped to the dance performances and later raved to her older brother about how much she had enjoyed them. That was the last conversation she had before going to bed at a tribal residential school in Dhanora, Gadchiroli district, in Maharashtra. The programme honoured tribal culture, and gave a call for tribal empowerment.

For Anu and her two older siblings studying here, their only hope for a better future away from poverty was this tribal residential school. For them, and for the two generations of Gonds, a Scheduled Tribe, who studied in the private, aided primary and secondary Ashram School in Japtalai in Dhanora, empowerment meant a window to education.

On the intervening night of August 9 and 10, as Anu and 111 girls in the school lay on the hostel floor, a common krait found its way into the dormitory. It bit six girls, all between 8

and 14 years, killing three. Anu was one of them.

One of the girls was airlifted to a hospital in Nagpur, Maharashtra’s no. 2 capital. She is now home and recovering. One continues to be serious, on ventilator support, at a hospital in Gadchiroli, but out of danger. Another is on her way to recovery.

Residents question the lack of medical and general infrastructure in one of the most underdeveloped and remote parts of Maharashtra, Gadchiroli. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis is its Guardian Minister. Gadchiroli, earlier a part of the Red Corridor, is the eastern-most district of Maharashtra. It has a dense forest cover of over 75%, with rich wildlife. In the last five years, 99 people have died of snakebite in Gadchiroli.

Teachers and parents say there are several questions to be answered by those in power, around the lack of school infrastructure, the lack of an ambulance and accessible medical services, and a deficient road network.

The tragic night

The school where the incident occurred was run by veteran Congress leader and former MP Marotrao Kowase. He is among the

five against whom separate FIRs have been registered under several bailable sections. The school’s licence will be cancelled, the Maharashtra government has said. They are also appointing a third party to audit all the 513 private, aided residential tribal schools in the State, Tribal Affairs Minister Ashok Uike told the media.

In Japtalai village, the orange school building stands out against the backdrop of fresh green fields, the colours of the Indian flag. From its population of 1,000 to 1,200 people, around 50 local children study in this school. Most of the children on the rolls are from Etapalli, a village at least five hours away by road. There are no beds, only mattresses. The only bed is the one for the cook, a contractual worker, who was with the girls at night.

Now, there are mosquito nets, newly fitted. “Had they been there that night, the snake could not have entered. We had raised this so many times in the past, but nobody paid attention,” says school’s cook Tanabai Sanku Durve. She was sleeping with the girls on the night of the incident, to fill in for the school’s woman supervisor, who had allegedly

Taken by one of the big four

Governance problems bedevil Maharashtra’s forested area, where three girls died from snakebite at a residential tribal school



Family members of Anu Koreti, who was 8 years old when she died of snakebite in Gadchiroli district, Maharashtra. EMMANUEL YOGINI

gone on leave without the principal’s approval. She is currently absconding after an FIR has been registered against her for negligence.

Near the window are fresh tyre marks. The parents say the pile of bricks and wooden logs have been removed from near the open windows.

“It is the most conducive environment for a snake. The wood is moist and cool. It is highly likely that these girls did not realise they were bitten by a

snake, because this snakebite feels like a mosquito bite,” says the Gadchiroli civil surgeon Dr. Varsha Shivaji Lahade. In fact, in many cases, it is difficult to find the fang marks too, she adds.

When the snake coiled itself around the leg of a fourth child, she woke up, and screamed in panic. The children, up and running, woke up the cook. “I hit the snake with a stick, but it kept moving. So I called the peon on my

Ashok Kumar  
GURUGRAM

A day after Union Minister of State for Planning and BJP’s Gurugram MP Rao Inderjit Singh publicly questioned the manner in which the party’s Partition Day programme was organised, senior party leader and former MP Kuldeep Bishnoi on Saturday came out in his support. He stressed that the experience of senior leaders must be respected while creating opportunities for the younger generation.

Mr. Singh, speaking at the BJP programme commemorating the horrors of Partition in Gurugram on Friday, had expressed dis-



Kuldeep Bishnoi

pleasure over the exclusion of local leaders from the event and said he objected to the fact that people from across the country had been invited for the event while local representatives had not.

Mr. Bishnoi took to “X” to back Mr. Singh, underlining the importance of respecting senior leaders

Suvendu promises to restore Bengal’s ‘old glory’ in I-Day speech

Shiv Sahay Singh  
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Saturday promised to restore the “old glory” of the State in his maiden Independence Day speech. “The dream of a developed India by 2047 can only be realised through a developed West Bengal,” he said during his address at Kolkata’s Red Road.

Mr. Adhikari, who was sworn in as the first Chief Minister from the Bharatiya Janata Party in West Bengal on May 9, 2026, said the priorities of his government include creating jobs, women empowerment and women security, and improving the law and order situation in the State.

While hoisting the Tricolour, the Chief Minister also recalled June 20, 1947, when he said West Bengal was incorporated with the rest of India.

Mr. Adhikari lauded Jana Sangh founder Syama Prasad Mookerjee as the architect of West Bengal. “Our two luminaries, Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay and Rabindranath Tagore, composed the



West Bengal CM Suvendu Adhikari during the flag hoisting ceremony at Red Road in Kolkata on Saturday. ANI

national song *Vande Mataram* and national anthem *Jana Gana Mana* respectively, which stirred the entire nation,” he said.

The Chief Minister also urged people to rise above political narrowness and join hands in the development of the State. He assured the gathering that the oath taken by him at Brigade Parade Grounds as CM will be honoured.

Mr. Adhikari honoured 14 IPS officers with the Chief Minister’s Medal for outstanding contribution. After the parade, a total of 12 tableaux were displayed. A tableau of Syama Prasad Mookerjee was also displayed at Red Road.

Bishnoi supports Rao Inderjit Singh, says ignoring seniors will weaken BJP

who have spent decades building the party and maintaining a public connect.

“The decades of political experience of senior leaders is the party’s invaluable asset,” Mr. Bishnoi said, adding that such leaders had witnessed political ups and downs, managed the organisation during difficult periods and earned their position through years of work among the people. He cautioned that ignoring senior leaders or sending any message that they were not being accorded due respect could weaken the organisation rather than strengthen it.

Referring specifically to Mr. Singh, Mr. Bishnoi said

the Union Minister had a “very significant stature” in Haryana politics and enjoyed a broad public base and respect. He added that he personally held him in high regard and admired his political experience, struggles and contribution to the State.

Balancing act

“The BJP is a strong organisation, and its strength lies in better coordination between the experience of senior leadership and the energy of young leadership. Respect for seniors and opportunities for the new generation - both must go hand in hand,” said Mr. Bishnoi, son of late Chief Minister Bhajan Lal.

earmarked for boys.

“We came to know only in the morning. The girls came to tell me that a snake had bitten my sister. I asked, which snake. They pointed towards the corner where the dead snake was. The moment I saw it, I got worried,” Karan says. He rushed to the teacher, who assured him that Anu was fine. She asked me to not call anyone,” he says, unable to hold back his anger and grief.

The Opposition has questioned the government over its apathy towards tribal students. “Reports indicate that in Maharashtra’s 1,056 ashram schools (schools set up for children of tribal communities), as many as 584 students have died in the past two years,” says NCP (SP) leader Jayant Patil, who adds that “the education system has become obsolete”.

Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Ambadas Danve says, “How can the project officer, whose lapse led to this incident, be the complainant in this case? Strict action should be taken against the senior government officials responsible for the lapse of overseeing the quality of these schools.”

vinaya.deshpande@the-hindu.co.in



# Classifieds

LIFE MADE SIMPLE

# Matrimonial

BRINGING PEOPLE TOGETHER

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| WEDDING ARRANGEMENTS                                                      |

## BRIDEGROOMS WANTED

### BENGALI

**BENGALI, KAYASTHA** ,GirI,33,170 Cm, B.Tech.Ir pretty working MNC Bangalore. Non veg, never married, seek educated groom, working in Bangalore. 70447 16088

### COSMOPOLITAN

**BEAUTIFUL VEGETARIAN** 32, 163cm, thoughtful, accomplished, UK-based (can relocate). Seeks compatible groom. Caste no bar. Call/WA 93456 34365

**34YRS BTECH (NIT)** MBA IIT working in MNC Chennai 24 LPA Fair looking for suitable match CNB Ct:9940507235

**PROPOSALS INVITED** from affluent families for Pillai / Nair girl, 26 years, raised in UK & USA, very pretty and modern, law graduate, for her remarriage. Caste or language – No issues.Contact: +1 602 491 5783

### DIVORCEE

**HINDU NADAR** family, well settled in Chennai invites alliance for their daughter, 41years, 158cm, wheatish, B.Tech in Biotech; M.S in Life Science(USA), self-employed, short marriage; no child, from a well educated, settled, professional groom from the same community with good family background, preferably a divorcee with no child; below 45years. WhatsApp groom's Profile & horoscope/ call: 9444895863.

**SAIVA MUDALIYAR** BE., 160 Cms, Aged 35 Years, Working in MNC Company @ Chennai, No Issues, Seeks Only Tamil Vegetarian. Ct : 6380723290

### DIVORCEE

**WARM, BEAUTIFUL** 49, sincere, responsible, progressive professional. Seeks kind, loyal, compatible groom. Caste no bar. Call/WA 93456 34365.

**TAMIL HINDU** 56y/173cm BSc, MBA, IT Prof., Australia Citizen, Divorcee. Seeks Bride, WhatsApp: +61422909407

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**CSI CHRISTIAN** Nadar, South Tamil Nadu, MBBS MD (Clinical Subject), 29/154, cheerful, pretty seeks same sect. Groom. PG / Student preferred. Send Bio-data 9487452271, 6381784394.

**Affluent Hindu Nadar Family invites an Alliance for their daughter:**  
32 yrs, 5'4", Fair, Doctor, currently in USA (willing to relocate) Belongs to a prominent, wealthy background. Seeking a well educated Groom, settled in USA or India.  
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**98431 44420**

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**Hindu Reddy fair girl, 30 years, Height 5'2" B tech from IIT, chennai, presently undergoing training as IFS officer; preferred; IAS/IPS/IFS and other central govt Group A&B officers; preferably General & OBC category.**

Contact what's App  
**9160666670**  
Mail ID  
**y.ram.ssa@gmail.com**

### KANNADA

**HINDU VOKKALIGA** Gowda 31, BE from Coimbatore seeks Suitable Groom. Contact: 97917 68175.

### MALAYALAM

**SC GIRL**, 38, MBBS, Central government Group A officer. Caste no bar. 8589881011.

### KERALA CATHOLIC BRIDE

**28/157, Fair, God-fearing. ACCA, IBM, Senior Auditor in Dubai, from a reputed joint Business family in Kochi. Seeks Catholic Groom, professionally qualified or one from a business background (preferably Dubai-based), from a respectable family; God-fearing and teetotaler.**

**Mob: 7025883117**  
**Email: georgematt2568@gmail.com**

### TAMIL

**MUSLIM** 31/168 MS Gen Surgery Seeks Prof Qualified groom Ct : 8220042091 mudlulhasafi@gmail.com

**SINGAPORE TAMIL** Muslim girl, aged 35yrs looking Engineering/ overseas studied lawyer etc., overseas working/experienced boy whatsapp details/photos to +6561399152/+592720042

**RC VANNIYAR**, 33/157, good looking / (MD Anesthesia) CMC Vellore, Ardent Christian, God-fearing & cultured. Parents in glory. Caste No Bar. Seeks well-educated, God-fearing, responsible Christian groom from respectable family. Contact/ WhatsApp: 9381725825

**MBBS** 31 Christian DKV Govt MBBS PG Doctors. Grp1/2 Officers preferred 7904678043

**ROMAN CATHOLIC**, Private, searching for a groom from 27-31 from any subcaste anywhere in India. 8138900487

### TAMIL

**CATHOLIC, DIVORCED**, M.Sc, looking for a groom from 35-41 from any Christian from 2nd marriage profiles, 8137001255

**PENTECOST, B.A.R.C.H**, Business, 10 C PA, looking for a bride for our daughter from 23-28 in TN,Karnataka, Pondi, 8137003550

**CSI, PHD**, Seeking for a groom from 28-32 from equal caste in Tamilnadu, 8137001247

**TAMIL MUSLIM** 24 Years MBA Seeks Groom working in UAE, USA, India. For Details Contact: 98431 95231.

**CHRISTIAN, DOCTOR, 39 Years Unmarried, Well Settled Family. Seeks Unmarried Doctor Groom. Ct: 7550286805**

**BORN AGAIN** Christian, 45yrs/152, MBBS, MD doctor, seeks christian groom, Chennai. Ct – 9500188067

**PROTESTANT, MS**, Private, looking for a groom from 28-33 from Rich/affluent in USA or India who willing to relocate, 8137001247

**ROMAN CATHOLIC**, 32, Business, MBA, looking for any Christian, upper middle or rich groom profile in Pondi-cherry or Tamilnadu, Kerala, 8138900412

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**PILLAI/NAIDU** 31/160 MBBS MS MRCS Doing Moh Bangalore Seeks PG Doctors Ch. Bangl ok CNB Geetham 9884858014

**CHETTIAR (CNB)**: 28/ V.Fair, MBBS, Preparing for PG, Father Business, Elite Family, Seeks groom Doctor / Business – 9862685839, 8925019776

**VELLALAR, AGE–38, MBBS,MD**, Star.Magam, never married. Well settled, Sub Caste ok. 7305460763/ 8754756329

**VANNIYAKULA SHATHRIYAR**, BDS, 29 Yrs, Pooram, Employed in Chennai, Looking for Groom Govt, Bank officer and Professional. CT : 9841550165.

**GROOM WANTED** Rich Mudaliar,28yrs, MBA, Running own industries in Chennai. Ph:9952619776

**HINDU SC/AD**, Age:45, 153cm, Ashwini (Mesha Rasi) B.Sc. MBA Fair & Good Looking girl from Well to do Family. Seeking Engrs/Doctors/ Grade-1 Officers. Ct: 9994219315 / 9943629339

**SC PR**, Divorcee no issue, 32yrs, B.E CSC, fair, well settled in Madurai, seeks suitable groom from reputed family. 97901 27249, 75399 28516

**NADAR** 35/5'6" MBA working in Chennai Elite Family Seeks qualified Groom working in Cennai, only Hindu-. 9962991979

**BRIDEGROOM WANTED** For a well-to-do hindu, family's bride age 43, first marriage, degree-MSW, want from (FC, BC, MBC), working within India. Ct: 90803–59664.

**GROOM WANTED** Naidu,27yrs, Divorce, MBBS, MS,Well Educated family in Chennai Ph:6385293227

**GROOM WANTED** Rich Mudaliar,27yrs, MBBS, MS, Well Educated family in Chennai Ph:7200187009

**GROOM WANTED** Hindu Nadar 28yrs,BE,SWE,1.5L p/m, well educated family Ph:9841329471, 9380791999

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✓ **ALLIANCE INVITED** for 26 year-old, Tamil, SC, well educated, postgraduate daughter, working with a leading corporate law firm dealing in Capital Markets, advising reputed companies and banks on IPOs and major financial transactions. Intelligent, family-oriented with a modern outlook and strong values. Seeking a well-educated, professionally accomplished groom, from a respectable family. Ph 9444415358

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### TAMIL

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**MUDALIAR** 24/163 Fair, B.Tech, SWE, Amazon, Bangalore, 2000000 PA, Affluent .CNB. 9043991629, 9043987029 9345634365

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**Hindu, Kulalar/Udayaara, 44 yrs, 170 cms, M.Tech, IT professional, Caste open for discussion. First Marriage Only**  
**CT: 93842 76066**

**VANNIYAR Chettiar**, 29 yrs beautiful, C.A.working in MNC Bangalore. We prefer Hindu Groom with C.A/Financial Executive/M.E/M.Tech only working in Bangalore or Chennai Tamil speaking Non-Vegetarian from Chettiar Mudaliar and Pillai.Please send horoscope & other details only to WhatsApp-No.9444587465.

**Tamil, Good Family** 29Yrs, B.Tech, MBA (BIM), 26 LPA, seeks suitable Groom, CNB. Contact: 9441677205.

**Tamil, Good Family**, 26Yrs, B.Sc(OU), UMC, Fair Girl seeks suitable Groom, CNB. Contact: 9441677205.

### TELOGU

**VB TELUGU** bride, 1992, 5'6", fair, M.A., working in Digital India. Seeks Telugu groom, 34 to 37 yrs, 5'9" above Ph: 9866970713 / 8106366930.

**NAIDU** 26/168, Fair, Beautiful, B.Tech, Tech Lead, Wipro, 2500000 PA, Affluent, CNB. 9043991629, 9043987029

**KAMMA (ANY-TELUGU)** 28/ V.Fair & Beautiful, Under graduation, Running Own Boutique, Chennai, Elite Family, Seeks Groom Business / Job– Ct: 8608626666

**SC, 35 YEARS / 152cm**, Pharm.D, PhD, Divorce, No kids, seeks Groom - india & abroad, caste no bar. Contact.9700019949.

### URDU

**SUNNI MUSLIM** 27y 171cms B'ul Docr Girl doing DM Endocrinology Iff affluent family. Seek Doc/Professionally q'lfid match. WA/call 9449671312

**SUNNI MUSLIM** girl, 1994 born, 164 cm, B.Tech, working in PSU Bank, Mumbai. Well-educated family from UP; father retired Addl. Director. Seeks suitable match. #9461179587

## BRIDES WANTED

### COSMOPOLITAN

**SMART, SUCCESSFUL** 44, well-read professional. Never-married. Seeks well-educated compatible bride. Caste/language no bar. Call/WA 9345634365

**37YRS, B-TECH** mgr govt Bank salary 1.5 LPM owning properties in CH, Seeking alliances CNB. 9940507235

**HINDU BRAHMIN** (46) Vegetarian. Finance Manager. Second marriage, no liabilities, looking for a bride, no location preference. 7559934483.

**PROFESSIONALLY QUALIFIED** Hindu Groom 178CM In His Late40s Who Is Family Oriented Values Traditions Living Overseas Seeks Suitable Remarriage Alliance From Bride Who Is Mutually Respecting Progressive, Enjoys Companionship And Have Good Family Values. Private Email: proporsalsinvited@gmail.com

### DIVORCEE

**SUCCESSFUL, HARVARD-EDUCATED**, calm, outgoing professional, 37. Cultured family. Seeks compatible bride. Caste no bar. Call/WA 9345 634 365

**IYER, 2ND** Marriage, 44, B.E, Mirugaseerdam, MNC Chennai, Suitable Vegetarian bride wanted. 7418006626

**REDDY, SWATHI**, 30/183 BE, MS London, Business, divorced seeks educated, good family background 9710933159

**Nair Chennai** Settled 42/177, B.Tech, Masters, Own Business, Divorced, No Child. No Bar. Phone: 9841757356

### ENGINEER

**Railway Senior** Section Engineer Thiyya (Kerala) 34 Years, seeks Bride Contact - 9495881105

### HINDI

**1985/175CM**, 50 Lakhs PA, Never Married, Bangalore. WhatsApp: 96290 12248

### MALAYALAM

**RC BOY**, 39/180, SSE, Railways, Eranakulam, girls above 35 years working in Kerala preferred. Send Bio-Data to 9495269815.

**Alliance invited** for Hindu Nair groom, 32/168, NIFT, M.Sc. (Saxon), well-settled professional in the Netherlands, never married, Seeking educated, family-oriented Hindu Nair bride. Horoscope preferred. Contact:7012904828.

### SAURASHTRA

**SAURASHTRA, 40**, 1st Marriage, Astham, Kanni, MBA, Finance, Senior Manager, Pvt, Chennai 1.50 Lakhs pm, Seeks Suitable Bride. CNB. 9381725577

### TAMIL

**CHRISTIAN TAMIL** 44/175cm BE, MBA Australia MNC. Divorcee No issues. seeks suitable Bride. Ct: 9094677765

**CHRISTIAN NADAR**, Doctor, MBBS, PGDCC-P (NI), Cardio Physician, Divorcee issueless, 38yrs/178cm, lives in Nagercoil seeks qualified / divorced bride. Ct: 90039 83230

**RC CHRISTIAN**, 43yrs/170, B.E. Software Engineer, never married, works for mnc, Chennai. CT- 9500188067

**AUDITOR/47** Chennai/ Seeks Any Vegetarian Hindu Girl. Contact : 9884398109

**BRIDE WANTED** Rc Nadar 32yrs.B. tech, SWE 1lp/m, educated family Ph:9380791999,9841329471

**BRIDE WANTED** Mudaliyar,26yrs,BE, Elite business family in Chennai Ph: 6385293227

**BRIDE WANTED** Naidu, 32yrs,MBA, Own Constructions,Elite business family in Chennai Ph:9952619776

**BRIDE WANTED** Mudaliyar, 28yrs.B. Tech,Elite business family in Chennai Ph: 9384772710

**NAIDU GROOM** Aug 81 born Surgeon BDS & UK MBA seek suitable compatible PQ DR Engr or IT working in India or Abroad CNB. Groom working in Bang as CEO of Hospital. 98867 82390/ 99622 46305

**BRIDE WANTED** for Yadava, Konar boy 1996/190cm B.Tech/MBA, handsome, clean habits, Bangalore based, currently working as VP in JPMC, USA. Open to come back to India, seeks bride from same cast, bangalore based or educated in bangalore. Reply with horoscope, photograph. Ct: 9880343417.ramakrishnan737@gmail.com

**VANNIYAKULA KSHATHRIYA Tamilnadu Boy** 32 Yrs USA based Seeks Girl below 30 USA based. Ct: 9597937384

**BRIDE WANTED** Naidu,32yrs, BE, Elite business family in Chennai, Landlord Ph: 6385293227

**HINDU-BE-SWE.35YRS.172CMS.33LPA,AYI LLAM-KADAGAM** SETTLED in Bangalore, financially stable ,Looking for suitable Bride. Ph 9845401461.

**THEVAR, 39** yrs/178 cm, B.Tech, M.S., Biotech Consultant,Working in NewZealand, Planning to relocate US,Remarriage/No issue.wa +919176329069

**BRIDE WANTED** Tamil Mudaliar 33yrs BE MS ( USA ) working in Kuwait as Engineer seeks suitable bride. Ct : 8056229298

### TAMIL

**VELLALAR** 38 C.G Officer swati Thulam 14L PA seeks bride 2nd marriage 9840666103

**Hindu, Tamil**, Thuluva Vellala, (Non-veg), only Son, 29yrs, 173 cm, Fair, M.Tech., PhD, Gold Medalist, Employed, well settled affluent Family. Seeking Bride Good Looking, at least 3yrs younger, well Educated with Family and Traditional values, from well settled affluent family of Thuluva Vellala/ Sozhiya Vellala/ Pillai/ Mudaliar. Contact: 9443083410

**HINDU, SC(AD)**, 33/165, Divorcee (No Children, Marriage for 3 Months) Mesham, Bharani, B.E, Senior HR Manager, Reputed IT Co. Chennai, Non-Veg, Seeks suitable working professional from respectable, cultured family. Caste No bar. Mob: 9080980356. Send BHP to gva.chennai06@gmail.com

**VISWAKARMA** 32/175 Self Employed/ Freelancer, Soft-Spoken, belongs to affluent & Cultured Family Seeking Bride.Minor imperfections/soft defects may be considered with overall compatibility. Ct: 9789063534, Chennai

**HINDU/ THEVAR**, Star– Revathi, Lagnam– Meenam / MBBS from Govt. Medical College, Now pursuing M.S – Ophthalmology 2nd year with Rama Medical College, Kanpur. 33Yrs / 180 cm , was working with Govt. Railway Hospital at Mumbai, from Metropolitan, Affluent family. Seeks MBBS Bride, Never Married, from Thevar/ Maravar / Agamudaiyar from Respectable, Elite Family. Contact: 9869164779 / 9821311011

**AGE 33**, MBA Asst Manager – PNB. Sc,Ad, Ragu Kethu Dosham Seeking Compatible Bride Vellore. Ct: 9443392722

**NAIDU**, 29/165, M.E., Design Engr L & T, own business & rental income, affluent family, Star: Thiruvonam, Rasi: Magaram, Seeking suitable alliance. CNB: 9841097110

**MUDALIAR** 30/182 B.Tech, MS.PRI. EGR,Microsoft, B.Lore 4000000 PA, Elite 40 Cr, CNB, 9043991629, 9043987029

**ALLIANCE invited** for a 44 yr old Tamil Brahmin groom, Engg graduate with Master's degree from Duke University, USA. Well settled and successfully managing his family business with average monthly income of 5 lakhs with own house in Chennai. Seeking family oriented girl between 35-42 yrs pref vegetarian and willing to settle in Chennai. Language no bar. Interested families may send BHP to Email: alliance.chennai.1982@gmail.com

### TAMIL</







From Page One

PM Modi warns against ‘intellectual Naxals’

“For years, people with a Maoist ideology had established themselves in the corridors of power and influenced policymaking, including as advisers on government committees” the Prime Minister said. “They are trying to revive the paths of violence and anarchy, and are making various attempts to drag society in the wrong direction. We must identify these intellectual Naxalites and isolate them. At the same time, we must connect the country’s young generation with the mainstream effort to build a developed nation,” he added.

He announced a full review and restructuring of civil defence infrastructure. “The nature of warfare is changing. There is no guarantee that wars will now be fought only along the borders,” the Prime Minister said. “A new form of warfare is emerging... Attacks can target a refinery, the banking sector, or a data centre. Infrastructure can be destroyed and factories can be targeted. We had announced Mission Sudarshan Chakra, [a multi-layered defence infrastructure system, with AI and cybersecurity components] last year, and work on it is going on rapidly,” he added.

A large part of the Prime Minister’s speech was devoted to what he termed ‘*Saptadhara*’ or the seven economic streams where his government was committed to reforms for growth. This includes manufacturing power with emphasis on quality; agriculture and food processing; technology and innovation as evidenced by the opening of the private sector for space exploration, and operationalisation of seven or eight semiconductor plants in the next year or two; the PM Gatishakti plan for multi-modal connectivity; enhanced domestic capabilities in armament production; a green and blue economy; and the projection of India’s soft power, including via yoga, tourism, and animation.

Mr. Modi recalled that, when he had first promoted his ‘Make in India’ initiative, advocates of globalisation had reacted as though it was heresy. In the current global economy, however, every country is thinking for itself, he pointed out.

The government has targeted the creation of 100 GW of nuclear energy capacity by 2047, Mr. Modi said, adding that five new reactors will be made operational in the next six to seven years.

Farmers, police clash in Haryana during protest

“There was so much crowd at that time. To disperse them... to keep them away, police also had to do it,” the SP said.

The All-India Kisan Sabha (AIKS) Haryana State Committee condemned the police action, alleging that protesters were subjected to a lathi charge and that several people were arrested at different entry points to Hansi. AIKS national vice-president Inderjit Singh demanded the immediate release of the arrested leaders, the return of the impounded vehicles, and the arrest of the accused in Kundu’s murder. Opposition leaders also criticised the police action.

Five killed amid heavy rainfall in Arunachal

The four workers killed in Upper Subansiri were identified as Tadu Baki, Taji Rai, Markosh Basumatari, and Babul Ali. Officials said only Ali’s body was recovered before the search was suspended due to operational constraints by Friday evening. They were working on a project under the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana.

In Anini, teams from the Army’s 5th Grenadier, the Indo-Tibetan Border Police’s 58th Battalion, 62 Road Construction Company of the General Reserve Engineer Force, the State police, and local volunteers joined the search operation.

The death of the woman Sarti occurred when a light commercial pick-up truck fell off the road into Lohit river at around 6 a.m. The Anjaw DDMO said the vehicle plunged about 300 feet below the road running along a cliff. While six people were rescued, a woman was confirmed dead, and three others were missing, an official said.

Govt. brings scheme to disclose foreign assets

There are two categories of declarations under FAST-DS. For an undisclosed foreign asset or foreign income that was not previously offered to tax, the aggregate value must not exceed ₹1 crore. A second category covers foreign assets that were already offered to tax or acquired when the taxpayer was a non-resident but were not reported in the relevant tax-return schedule. The threshold for such declarations is ₹5 crore, with a ₹1 lakh fee payable.

The CBDT said the scheme is intended to enable eligible taxpayers to disclose “certain undisclosed foreign assets, undisclosed foreign income, or undeclared foreign assets” on payment of the specified tax or fee.

For example, where an undisclosed foreign bank account is valued at ₹60 lakh and undisclosed foreign income amounts to ₹20 lakh, the total tax payable would be ₹48 lakh, according to an example in the CBDT’s frequently asked questions.

Bar and Bench committed to your growth, CJI tells youth

The Chief Justice’s message comes after Bar Council’s attempt to stop professional enrolment of 2026 batch of NALSAR University students; he praises the youth’s resilience and social awareness

Krishnadas Rajagopal  
NEW DELHI

The Chief Justice of India, Surya Kant, in his Independence Day address at the Supreme Court on Saturday, said the younger generation’s “remarkable resilience”, awareness of social realities, and their use of technology to communicate and access knowledge give the nation every reason to be confident in them.

“This generation brings with it qualities that give us every reason to be confident. They have grown up in a world where technology has transformed the way we communicate and access knowledge, and they are bringing that adaptability into the courtroom. At the same time, they bring a greater awareness of the social realities around them,” Chief Justice Kant said, referring to young law graduates and lawyers.

Young lawyers show deep sensitivity to questions of equality, inclusion and access to justice, and with an understanding that the law must remain connected to the lives and aspirations of the people it



CJI Surya Kant hoists the National Flag during the 80th Independence Day celebrations at the Supreme Court. PTI

serves, the Chief Justice said.

“To our young law graduates and young lawyers, I want to say this – the responsibility that this Bar has carried since the days of the freedom struggle will, before long, rest on your shoulders. The institutions of justice that generations before you have built and strengthened are now yours to protect and to carry forward. Please know that the Bar and the Bench remain committed to your growth – by extending mentorship, by creating meaningful opportunity, and by placing our confidence in you. The miles that remain are yours to walk, and we walk with

you,” Chief Justice Kant said.

Chief Justice Kant’s focus in his Independence Day address on the younger generation of law graduates and lawyers came after the Bar Council of India’s (BCI) half-baked move to stop the professional enrolment of the entire 2026 batch of NALSAR (National Academy of Legal Studies and Research) University of Law graduates.

The BCI’s actions had invited public ire, followed by condemnation from the Supreme Court itself.

Chief Justice Kant, in an oral mention of a petition against the BCI on Friday, had upheld the students’

right to protest. The CJI had said in open court that the students’ objection to his coming to their convocation ceremony as chief guest was part of a “dialogue” between them and him, and the BCI had no business bargaining in.

The Chief Justice had protected NALSAR students and faculty from any punitive action by the BCI. The top judge had even urged the graduates to enrol with the Supreme Court Bar and take up legal aid work.

‘More competitive’

The Chief Justice commended the younger generation for their “remarkable resilience”.

The challenges in law and life were far greater today than were faced by earlier generations, the top judge said.

“The profession is more competitive today, the learning curve has become steeper, and the pressures of building a practice weigh heavily in these early years. And yet, I have also seen in our young colleagues a remarkable resilience, a sharp intellect, and a genuine commitment to justice,” Chief Justice Kant said.

Youth can become a burden without jobs, skills: Bhagwat

Ishita Mishra  
NEW DELHI



Mohan Bhagwat

India’s young population could become a powerful engine of growth if nurtured properly, said Rashtriya Swayamsewak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat on Saturday, warning that it could also become a burden if the youth were not properly equipped, employed and guided.

Speaking to young people at an event organised by the Lokmat Media Group to mark the 80<sup>th</sup> Independence Day in Nagpur, Mr. Bhagwat described India’s youth as a “demographic dividend”.

“If the youth are nurtured well, they can become an asset for the nation and help the country realise its ambition of becoming a “Vishwaguru” (world leader), but if not, they could become a burden on society,” he said.

Distinct strategy

He asserted that India should develop an approach suited to its own circumstances rather than measure its progress by comparing itself with countries such as the U.S., China, Australia, New Zealand and Canada. “India needs to establish its own benchmarks for progress

after studying its challenges carefully,” he said, adding that the country’s large population, limited geographical space and different resource base require a distinct development strategy.

The event marked Mr. Bhagwat’s second interaction with Gen Z in ten days. On August 6, he had defended young people protesting against irregularities in the NEET paper leak, saying their grievances were genuine and that protesting did not make them “anti-national”.

At another Independence Day event at Kasturchand Park in Nagpur, the RSS chief said democracy allows for diverse ideas and ways for expressing them. He emphasised that dialogue, debate and the exchange of arguments are essential to the democratic process.

Protesters take out ‘Tiranga Yatra’ in Ranchi on day 22; CM Soren vows ‘systemic change’

Amit Bhelari  
PATNA



An aerial view of job aspirants and students taking out a 'Tiranga Yatra' during their protest against irregularities in Jharkhand government recruitment exams, in Ranchi on Saturday. PTI

Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren on Saturday used his Independence Day address to assure students that their hard work would not be left at the mercy of any mafia, corrupt systems or question paper leaks as the protest in Ranchi against irregularities in State government recruitment exams entered its 22nd day.

Hundreds of protesting students and job aspirants took out a “Tiranga (Tricolour) Yatra” in Ranchi city. They have been demanding an inquiry by the CBI and action against those responsible for alleged irregularities in competitive exams for government jobs in the State, including in the JPSC Examination and the Jharkhand General Graduate Level Combined Competitive Examination.

Mr. Soren, while addressing a gathering at Mo-

rabadi Ground in Ranchi after hoisting the Tricolour, promised “systemic change” and described Jharkhand’s youth as its greatest asset as the State looks to grow over the next 25 years.

“Today, I want to assure every student in Jharkhand that your hard work will

not be left at the mercy of any mafia, corrupt system, or irregularities,” Mr. Soren said. Promising an impartial investigation into the issues, the Chief Minister said, “The law will deal sternly with anyone found guilty. No matter how influential a person may be, if their involvement is pro-

ven, they will not be spared.”

Mr. Soren promised a time-bound annual examination calendar, a transparent examination system secured with the help of technology, timely availability of answer keys and OMR sheets, and multi-level accountability within

the examination process.

However, the protesters have said they would not withdraw the stir until the government addresses their demands, including cancellation of examinations in which alleged irregularities were found.

Call for gherao

Demanding Mr. Soren’s resignation, JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch leader Ravindra Paswan said, “We will gherao the Chief Minister’s residence on August 20. We seek his resignation as both the JMM and the Congress are playing politics with us. We also demand that Congress leader Rahul Gandhi withdraw support to the JMM-led coalition if the Chief Minister is not listening to him”.

The protesters also said that they would burn effigies of the Chief Minister and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi across all 24 districts on Sunday.

(With PTI inputs)

Devendra Mahto alleges assault by Ranchi police

Amit Bhelari  
PATNA

Jharkhand Loktantrik Krantikari Morcha (JLKM) leader Devendra Nath Mahto, who has been undergoing treatment at Ranchi Sadar Hospital, rebuked the Ranchi police for stopping him when he tried to take part in the Tiranga Yatra organised by the protesting students on the occasion of 80<sup>th</sup> Independence Day.

Mr. Mahto, who is leading the faction of JPSC-JSSC Nyay Manch, has been on a hunger strike for the past 14 days in support of the demands raised by the students over alleged irregularities in the recruitment examination in Jharkhand.

When the police did not allow him to leave the room where he was admitted, an altercation took place between police personnel and Mr. Mahto. The JLKM leader alleged that he sustained an injury to his chest while being stopped and jostled by the police. Mr. Mahto also alleged that the police assaulted and beat up his associates who came to rescue him.

He also shared the footage of the altercation on his official social media account.

“For 14 days, I have been on a hunger strike, and today the police tried to push and forcefully stop me along with my companions. The police also assaulted my people who were with me,” Mr. Mahto wrote on X.

After the alleged assault, Mr. Mahto, along with his people, sat down on dharna right outside his room.

“Until I am allowed to leave from here, I will keep sitting right here. I will not even get my treatment done, and I will stay here to raise my concern. My fight is for the rights of the people and for justice. They (Police) cannot silence my voice by stopping me,” Mr. Mahto said.

External forces behind Gen Z protest: Odisha CM

Satyasundar Barik  
BHUBANESWAR

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi on Saturday reiterated his earlier stand, saying external forces were behind the Gen Z protest, which was critical of the BJP government over its education policy.

“Over the past few days, certain external forces, both within and outside the country, have been attempting to mislead the youth of the nation,” said Mr. Majhi, addressing the the 80<sup>th</sup> Independence Day event in Bhubaneswar. Prime Minister Narendra Modi will not compromise an inch for the nation’s interests, he added.

CJP founder launches a campaign to set right school education system

The Hindu Bureau  
MUMBAI/JAIPUR

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke began the “School *theek karo*” (fix the school) campaign at a government school in his native village of Santuk Pimpri in Hingoli district of Maharashtra.

“People have now understood that they should talk about education, which is the need of the hour. No matter which political party ruled, nobody worked for government schools in States. Now there is a need, and we can make them work by asking questions,” Mr. Dipke said, after interacting with the students. Comparing the money spent on political



CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke interacting with students at a Zilla Parishad school in Santuk Pimpri village in Maharashtra. PTI

banners on the Tiranga campaign with those spent for schools, he said that “Had this money been spent on schools and students in rural areas, it would have been even better. They should think

about the future of school students.”

Rajasthan protest

About 50 activists of the CJP, led by its co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka, joined a protest by students and lo-

cal residents at a government school in Rajasthan’s Alwar district against the dilapidated condition of the school and a shortage of teaching staff.

The Government Senior Secondary School at Jodha was had seen a slab fall from its roof earlier this week. Moreover, five of the six senior teachers’ posts in the school are vacant.

Addressing the protesters, Mr. Ranka said there were about 84,000 classrooms in Rajasthan that were in dilapidated conditions, putting the future of 15 lakh children at risk. “If the BJP government fails to repair these classrooms, it should brace itself for the largest protest in the State’s history,” he said.



# Sonia tried to stop Vande Mataram, claims BJP; Congress rejects charge

The controversy comes amid the Home Ministry's guidelines mandating full rendition of *Vande Mataram*; Congress maintained that Sonia was merely seeking a chair for Mallikarjun Kharge and that the National Song was rendered in full

**Sandeep Phukan**  
NEW DELHI

The rendition of the full six stanzas of *Vande Mataram* at the headquarters of the Indian National Congress triggered a controversy on Saturday after the Congress Parliamentary Party (CPP) chairperson Sonia Gandhi was seen gesturing during the song, prompting the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to allege that she had tried to stop it, while the Congress denied the charge.

At a ceremony to hoist the National Flag at Indira Bhawan here, Ms. Gandhi was seen gesturing towards Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge while the National Song was being sung. A Seva Dal volunteer then approached the CPP chairperson and spoke to her.

Subsequently, Ms. Gandhi and the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi were seen having an animated discussion with Seva Dal chief B.V. Srinivas, and his predecessor Lalji Desai.



Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge alongside Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and Ajay Maken at AICC headquarters in New Delhi on Saturday. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

A hot mic situation purportedly revealed Mr. Gandhi was saying that the Congress was singing “our version of *Vande Mataram*.”

“Today, on Independence Day, when *Vande Mataram* was sung in its entirety in keeping with the sentiments of millions of Indians, the sight of Congress’s supreme leader Sonia Gandhi, super president Rahul Gandhi, and

current president Mallikarjun Kharge conversing with one another and displaying disrespect at the Congress office at the very same time is utterly bizarre, ironic, and unfortunate,” BJP spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi said in a post on social media platform X.

“We condemn this conduct of the Congress party’s top leadership and expect the Congress party to

apologise to the nation for it,” Mr. Trivedi said.

Defending the party’s position, Congress’s communications chief Jairam Ramesh said Ms. Gandhi had been asking for a chair for Mr. Kharge. “As the Congress president was standing for a long time, Sonia ji was asking for a chair for him,” Mr. Ramesh claimed. “But today, at Indira Bhawan, the full version [of the *Vande Mata-*

*ram*] was sung. There is no question of a controversy over it,” he added.

Mr. Ramesh cited history to argue Rabindranath Tagore had suggested that only the first few stanzas of *Vande Mataram* be sung. On October 28, 1937, a meeting of the Congress Working Committee was held in Calcutta.

“On the advice of Gurudev Rabindranath Tagore, they decided that the initial stanzas of *Vande Mataram* would be sung at Congress sessions,” Mr. Ramesh said, adding that Tagore had given this advice to Nehru and Bose.

The Congress had opposed the Bill that added criminal provisions to an alleged insult while singing *Vande Mataram*, he added.

The controversy assumes significance against the backdrop of guidelines issued by the Union Home Ministry in February, and reiterated in July, on the observance of the National Song, and the subsequent passage of the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Act, 2026.

# ‘Dimagi Naxals’ remark by Prime Minister draws criticism from Opposition

**The Hindu Bureau**  
NEW DELHI

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Saturday said that people raising their voices for their rights were not anti-national and extended the party’s support to peaceful protests by Gen Z, as the Opposition criticised Prime Minister Narendra Modi for his “*dimagi Naxals*” remark.

Addressing the Independence Day function at the All India Congress Committee headquarters, Mr. Kharge said attempts to label those questioning the government as anti-national were contrary to the values for which the freedom struggle was fought. “Gen Z, which raises its voice for its rights, is not anti-national,” he said.

Opposition parties objected to Mr. Modi’s use of the term “*dimagi Naxals*” (ideological or intellectual Naxals) in his address, alleging that it was an attempt to stigmatise dissent and intimidate those questioning the government. They criticised his appeal for political parties to help implement 33% reservation for women in legisla-

tures, alleging that the government had itself kept the quota in abeyance by linking it to delimitation.

Mr. Kharge said Independence meant freedom not merely from foreign rule but from poverty, discrimination, untouchability, unemployment, injustice and fear. He credited successive Congress governments with building institutions and introducing rights-based legislation, including the right to information, education, food and work.

He attacked the government over the treatment of protesting students, parliamentary accountability and the alleged theft of donations made to the Ram temple in Ayodhya. Mr. Kharge also alleged government interference in institutions such as the judiciary, Election Commission, universities and investigative agencies.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said Mr. Modi had first described his opponents as “urban Naxals” and was now calling them “*dimagi Naxals*”, terming it a “sure sign of his desperation”. He called the Prime Minis-

ter’s pitch for women’s reservation “dishonest”, pointing out that the legislation passed in 2023 was not implemented in the 2024 Lok Sabha election.

Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav urged the government to implement women’s reservation in the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly election. “The Red Fort is not a place from where one should speak lies,” he said.

CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby called the “*dimagi Naxal*” charge an “atrocious allegation”.

“This is a very convenient accusation that they are Maoists in their mind,” he said. He added that women’s reservation should be implemented in existing seats rather than being linked to delimitation.

CPI general secretary D. Raja said Mr. Modi had chosen to target dissenters even on Independence Day. “This is nothing but an attempt to stigmatise dissent and intimidate those who question the government,” he said, asking the Prime Minister to answer questions from students and youth on education and employment.

## On the draw



# Fadnavis backs PM’s ‘intellectual Naxals’ remark

**The Hindu Bureau**  
MUMBAI

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Saturday seconded Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s “intellectual Naxals” comment made during his Independence Day address in New Delhi.

Mr. Fadnavis said that while armed Naxalism had been defeated, an ideological form of Naxalism prevails.

Addressing the nation on the 80th Independence Day, Mr. Modi said “intellectual Naxals” (*dimagi Naxals*) have become part of the system and continue to pose a threat to society. He urged citizens to “iden-

tify and isolate” them.

Backing this statement, Mr. Fadnavis said: “I think the Prime Minister has made a very appropriate reference. Naxalism with a gun has ended. But, we are seeing a more dangerous kind of ‘*dimagi Naxalism*’.”

“Unfortunately, we saw one such example even at today’s Congress programme. The decision to play the complete *Vande Mataram* on August 15 was taken within the constitutional powers of the country. If reports that Sonia Gandhi was unhappy because the full *Vande Mataram* was played are true, then what else can this be but ‘*dimagi Naxalism*’ among people whose



Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis pays floral tributes to Krantijyoti Savitribai Phule in Mumbai on Saturday. ANI

minds are filled with anarchy,” he said.

### Women’s reservation

On the Prime Minister’s pitch to move a Bill to reserve seats for women in

Parliament, Mr. Fadnavis said parties opposing the proposal should understand the constitutional conditions attached to the 2023 legislation.

“Those who are selec-

tively reacting to the PM’s appeal on women’s reservation should remember that when the women’s reservation legislation was approved through a constitutional amendment in 2023, two conditions were put in it. The first was completion of the Census and the second was delimitation after the Census. Only after these two processes can the women’s reservation be implemented,” Mr. Fadnavis said. He also criticised Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge for their absence from the Independence Day function, saying opposition to the BJP should not be equated with opposition to the country.

## U.P. CM rolls out integrated policy for State’s youth

**Mayank Kumar**  
LUCKNOW

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Saturday announced a new ‘Youth Policy’ for Uttar Pradesh and described the youth as the State’s greatest strength.

At the Independence Day celebration organised at Vidhan Bhavan, Mr. Adityanath said, “Today, I am extremely pleased to announce that through the ‘Youth Policy’, we will succeed in further strengthening the skill, innovation and employment of the youth of the State through an integrated approach... The resolve to make proper use of the capabilities and potential of the youth will be given further momentum.” The upcoming policy is likely to focus on skill development, employment generation, AI and entrepreneurship.

“The strength of Uttar Pradesh lies in the talent of its youth. The government has taken strict action against the cheating mafia and recruitment mafia, and the state’s demographic dividend is being transformed into a ‘development engine,” he said.

# Return whatever was taken away from J&K, says Omar Abdullah

**Peerzada Ashiq**  
SRINAGAR

Terming federalism as “strength of the country”, Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, in his Independence Day speech in Srinagar on Saturday, said “whatever had been taken away from J&K” should be returned, in an oblique reference to the erstwhile special status under Article 370.

“Whatever was taken away from us should be returned to us. The idea of federalism should be pursued seriously by empowering States, not merely by granting Statehood status. Federalism should not remain limited to words but should be reflected in practice,” said Mr. Abdullah.

Without mentioning Article 370, the J&K Chief Minister was pitching for the return to the pre-2019 status of the Union Territory.

He also said, “Federalism suffers when central agencies interfere in matters falling within the States’ domain or when powers vested with States are eroded or exercised by central agencies.”

Referring to examina-



J&K CM Omar Abdullah at a parade during the Independence Day celebration at Bakshi Stadium in Srinagar. IMRAN NISSAR

tions such as NEET, NET and JEE, he said, “They have changed the manner in which admissions were conducted (earlier by the States themselves). National examinations were appropriate for national institutions such as IITs, IIMs and NIFT, while State educational institutions should have the right to conduct their own examinations and admissions,” he said.

### ‘A matter of regret’

He also referred to the situation in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), where scores of protesters died in firing by security forces over the past two months.

“The condition of people in that part of Jammu

and Kashmir was a matter of sadness and regret. They are our own people. The J&K Assembly has seats earmarked for them. If 2019 had not happened to J&K, people there [in PoK] would have been agitating to join this part,” said Mr. Abdullah.

Meanwhile, Mr. Abdullah also paid tribute to National Conference (NC) founder Sheikh Mohammad Abdullah and termed him the “greatest leader” and the “most courageous person” of J&K. “Any Independence Day reflection in J&K would remain incomplete without remembering his contribution,” he added. He also remembered NC leader Master

Abdul Aziz, who was killed in Muzaffarabad while resisting the tribal invasion into J&K in 1947.

J&K Lieutenant-Governor Manoj Sinha, who hoisted the National Flag at Lok Bhavan, said the truest tribute to the martyrs and freedom fighters “is to resolve to work with integrity and safeguard our hard-earned freedom”. Calling upon the people of J&K to dedicate themselves to nation-building, Mr. Sinha said, “Transparency and accountability in governance is a necessity.”

Jammu & Kashmir Peoples Democratic Party president Mehbooba Mufti called for making freedom meaningful for every Indian, saying independence is not merely about celebrating a day but about protecting the rights and dignity of citizens. In a post on X, the party wrote, “Independence is not merely the freedom to celebrate a day; it is the freedom to speak, to dissent, to dream and to live with dignity. On this Independence Day, let us reclaim the promise of our Constitution and make freedom meaningful for every Indian. Happy Independence Day.”

# Global partners greet India, reaffirm bilateral relations

**Press Trust of India**  
KATHMANDU/SINGAPORE

India’s global partners, including France, Russia and Australia, on Saturday extended greetings to the country on its 80th Independence Day, reaffirming their commitment to strengthening bilateral ties and regional cooperation.

French President Emmanuel Macron, Russian President Vladimir Putin, Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese and U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio were among leaders who hailed ties with India on the occasion.

Mr. Macron took to X to extend his greetings. “Congratulations to the Indian people on your 80th Independence Day!” he said.

Mr. Putin extended greetings to President Droupadi Murmu as well as Prime Minister Narendra Modi, expressing confidence that the constructive bilateral partnership will help enhance international security and stability.

The Russian President said Russia-India relations are developing successfully in the spirit of a “particu-

larly privileged strategic partnership”.

Earlier on Friday, Mr. Rubio also extended his greetings and asserted that the bilateral ties were stronger than ever due to the personal relationship between President Donald Trump and Mr. Modi.

“On behalf of the United States of America, I extend warm congratulations to the people of India on their Independence Day,” Mr. Rubio said, adding that bilateral collaboration is making both nations, and the broader Indian Ocean region, safer, stronger, and more prosperous.

Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese also conveyed his greetings on the occasion, asserting that India has gone “from strength to strength” in the eight decades since its independence.

Israeli Prime Minister Isaac Herzog also wished India’s top leadership and the “wonderful people” of the country on Independence Day. “May we continue to strengthen the beautiful friendship between Israel and India,” he said in a social media post.

## Shah: PM’s I-Day speech a Viksit Bharat milestone

**Press Trust of India**  
NEW DELHI

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Saturday said that Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s Independence Day address was imbued with the resolve for *Swadeshi* and prosperity and added that it will prove to be a milestone in the journey towards becoming a leading nation.

In a post on X, Mr. Shah said Mr. Modi outlined a comprehensive roadmap to build a ‘Viksit Bharat’ driven by the spirit of ‘nation first’, ‘drug-free’ and a ‘safe India’.

He said the Prime Minister highlighted the unprecedented progress made over the last 12 years in sectors such as semiconductors, critical minerals, energy, and railway transport. He presented the mantra of *Saptadhara* – seven pillars of strength – to propel the country to new heights, Mr. Shah said.

The Prime Minister set ambitious targets, such as achieving 100 gigawatts of nuclear power capacity and establishing eight new semiconductor units by 2047, he said.



INBRIEF



Mahua seeks LS Speaker’s intervention over eviction bid

Trinamool Congress MP Mahua Moitra has written to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, seeking his intervention in the West Bengal’s Nadia district administration’s alleged attempt to force her to vacate a Circuit House in Krishnanagar after she was allotted a room at the State-owned property. “I kindly request you to urgently look into the matter and take necessary steps to set an example and ensure the dignity of women parliamentarians. Any Women’s Reservation Bill seeking to bring in more women is a matter of jest unless your august office can protect the 74 women who have battled great odds to enter this House,” Ms. Moitra wrote in letter to Mr. Birla. PTI

Five killed as vehicle plunges into Chenab River in J&K

Five people were killed in Jammu and Kashmir’s Kishtwar district on Saturday after their vehicle skidded off the road and plunged into the Chenab River in the Dachhan area, officials said. Rescue teams are working to ascertain the identities of the deceased and determine the exact number of occupants in the vehicle. Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha said he is pained by the loss of five lives in a tragic road accident. “My heartfelt condolences to the bereaved families. Have directed the district administration and senior officials to ensure immediate assistance is provided to those affected,” he said. PTI

Teenager electrocuted while putting up flag at M.P. school

A 17-year-old boy died from electrocution while putting up the national flag for the Independence Day celebrations at a private school in Madhya Pradesh’s Datia, the police said on Saturday. According to the police, the incident took place on Friday afternoon at Little Star Public School in Datia town where Raj Kushwaha, a student, was called after school hours and sent to the rooftop to install the national flag at a pole. The boy suffered burn injuries after coming into contact with a 11 KV power line passing through the school roof. He died at the spot. An FIR has been registered against the school management and officials who sent the boy for the task, police said.

Death of jail inmate: Kishor seeks action within 10 days

Jan Suraaj founder Prashant Kishor on Saturday met Madhubani SSP in connection with the death of a man in Rampatti jail. The police have claimed that nineteen-year-old Roshan Yadav took his own life inside the jail last week. However, Yadav’s family members have questioned the police’s claim and alleged that he may have been killed, pointing to several marks on his body. “The SSP has agreed to probe every angle thoroughly. If appropriate action isn’t taken within 10 days, we will take the matter forward to the DGP,” said the Bankipur MLA. PTI  
(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help)

SUDOKU

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

Solution to yesterday’s Sudoku

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CAG audit highlights major gaps in Green India Mission

The report flags inadequate convergence with other schemes, insufficient funding and weak monitoring; GIM is one of eight missions under the National Action Plan on Climate Change

Jacob Koshy  
NEW DELHI

The Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) has flagged major shortcomings in the implementation of the Green India Mission (GIM), including inadequate funding, weak coordination between government schemes, poor monitoring, and failure to meet key targets for improving forest cover and its quality.

The Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change launched the GIM in 2014 with the aim of protecting, restoring, and enhancing the country’s forest cover.

The CAG’s audit examined the planning, implementation and monitoring of GIM interventions in 16 States and Union Territories between 2015-16 and 2024-25.

According to the audit report, while the target was to improve the quality of forest cover over 1.4 million hectares, improvement was observed only in 0.11384 million hectares – a “shortfall of 91.87%”.

Similarly, an increase in forest cover was recorded over only 0.03409 million hectares against a target of 1.4 million hectares, representing a 97.57% shortfall.

The GIM is one of eight missions under India’s National Action Plan on Climate Change. Its objectives include improving ecosystem services such as biodi-



Forest failings: Green India Mission is one of the key programmes to support India’s long-term low-carbon strategy. FILE PHOTO

versity, water and carbon sequestration, as well as increasing means of forest-based livelihood. The mission envisages increasing forest and tree cover over 5 million hectares and improving the quality of forest and tree cover over another 5 million hectares.

Tree cover

The mission is particularly important to India’s climate commitments because enhancing forest and tree cover is a central component of India’s Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC) under the Paris Agreement. India has committed to creating an additional carbon sink of 2.5-3 billion tonnes of CO2 equivalent by 2030 through additional forest and tree cover.

The government’s long-term low-carbon strategy identifies the GIM as one of the key programmes supporting this target.

The CAG attributed the

shortcomings to several factors, including inadequate convergence with other programmes, insufficient funding, deficiencies in planning and weak monitoring mechanisms.

The report found that the mission’s planned convergence with programmes such as the Compensatory Afforestation Fund Management and Planning Authority (CAM-PA) and the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (MGNREGS) was not effectively achieved. Other programmes, including Nagar Van Yojana and School Nursery Yojana, were also found to be operating largely in silos.

This lack of convergence also affected financing, the report said. The audit noted that the mission failed to secure ₹10,600 crore in proposed funding support. Against ₹2,000 crore approved by the Cabinet Committee on

Economic Affairs for the initial four years of the scheme, along with ₹400 crore from the 13th Finance Commission grants towards the States’ share, only ₹1,149.14 crore, or 47.88%, was received through budgetary support during the 10 years examined, the audit found.

The audit also found weaknesses in financial controls: eight States and Union Territories did not maintain annual accounts, while accounts in other cases were often unaudited or contained discrepancies.

Opposition’s criticism

The Congress criticised the government over the issues flagged by the CAG, with Rajya Sabha MP and former Environment Minister Jairam Ramesh calling the GIM a “gigantic fraud”. He said on X, “The Green India Mission has been a comprehensive failure – actually not just a failure but a gigantic fraud on the people of India.”

“When the Green India Mission was conceived in 2010 as part of (then) Prime Minister Manmohan Singh’s National Action Plan on Climate Change (NAPCC), it placed strong emphasis on monitoring, planning, and effective implementation. It was never meant to be another green-washing exercise, but a genuine effort towards sustainable environmental change,” Mr. Ramesh said.

‘Basic amenities are missing in 89% of audited stations’

Maitri Porecha  
NEW DELHI

An audit of passenger amenities and sanitation by the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) of India has revealed persistent and widespread deficiencies across Indian Railways.

A joint team of CAG and railway officials conducted an audit of 512 stations, of which 458 stations (nearly 89%) were deficient in one or more minimum essential amenities, including fans (42%), water coolers (40%), drinking water taps (27%), urinals (22%), seating arrangements (15%), platform shelters (13%), latrines (12%) and clocks (12%). “Only 54 stations (11%) had no shortfalls,” the report noted.

Of the 512 stations audited, 325 were non-Amrit Bharat stations. The Amrit Bharat Station Scheme is an ongoing initiative of the Railway Ministry, launched in 2022, to modernise over 1,300 railway stations across the country.

The CAG audited non-suburban stations handling long-distance passenger traffic of at least 150 km. The sample sizes were drawn from 5,908 stations across 16 railway zones running 7,424 passenger trains daily and serving 292.4 crore passengers as of 2023-24.

Systemic failure

While the fund allocation largely remained stable at ₹3,207 crore (2019-20),



The report recommends time-bound, station-wise plans to address concerns. FILE PHOTO

₹3,875 crore (2020-21), ₹3,414 crore (2021-22) and ₹3,351 crore (2022-23), it shot up to ₹14,072 crore in 2023-24. The CAG report noted a significant year-on-year underutilisation of budget grants – ₹1,403 crore (44%), ₹1,499 crore (39%), ₹1,423 crore (42%), ₹1,198 crore (36%) and ₹5,956 crore (42%) during the five-year period.

The report also noted that accessibility infrastructure for persons with disabilities was inadequate and non-compliant, with substantial deficiencies in accessibility infrastructure, information systems, toilets, ramps, tactile pathways, lifts and announcements.

The CAG report proposed that the Railways prepare and deploy station-wise, time-bound action plans to address amenity concerns, including effectively implementing accessibility provisions for persons with disabilities and strengthening sanitation management.

Assam govt. working to make State flood-resilient, says CM

The Hindu Bureau  
GUWAHATI

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Saturday said the State government was preparing a comprehensive rehabilitation plan for the flood-affected families in the State.

He said the focus of such a plan would be on rebuilding infrastructure, restoring livelihoods, and creating a more flood-resilient Assam.

In his 80th Independence Day message, the Chief Minister emphasised stronger infrastructure, reliable early-warning forecasts, and resilient livelihoods, maintaining that a rapid digital assessment of the flood damage would enable faster rehabilitation and reconstruction.

Earlier, he said Assam would require at least ₹1,000 crore to rebuild the flood-hit areas. Although a maximum of 16 districts experienced floods since



Himanta Biswa Sharma

April this year, eastern Assam’s Sivasagar, Charaideo, and Jorhat districts bore the brunt.

Death toll

According to the Assam State Disaster Management Authority, the floods have killed 104 people and affected up to 7.21 lakh people so far.

The Chief Minister said the government would help the eligible flood-affected people repair damaged houses and restore livestock, poultry, tube

wells, looms and textiles. “The government will also provide a loan repayment moratorium to ease the financial burden on such families,” he said in Guwahati’s Khanapara.

“During this difficult time, the government has not limited itself to providing relief. We are standing beside every flood-affected family and are working with urgency to help them return to normal life,” the Chief Minister said.

He also outlined his vision for a peaceful, self-reliant and opportunity-driven Assam, focusing on development, social reform, economic empowerment, and inclusive growth.

Meanwhile, Sivasagar MLA Akhil Gogoi began an indefinite hunger strike in Sivasagar on Saturday, demanding ₹10 lakh as compensation for each flood-affected family and commercial establishment in the State.

The Hindu Bureau  
GUWAHATI

The devastation caused by floods and landslides in Assam and Nagaland should not lead to friction between the people of the two northeastern States, a Nagaland-based coal miners’ association said.

People should refrain from making unverified claims, and start examining several factors that could have contributed to the extensive damage to lives, homes, livelihoods, property, and public infrastructure, the Tuli Area Coal Mining Contractors’ Association (TACMCA) urged.

Tuli, in Nagaland’s Mokochung district, is a town on the border with Assam. The coal belt on the border between the two States runs from Nagaland’s Wokha through Mokochung to Longleng, Mon, and further beyond in Arunachal Pradesh.

Floods in Assam and landslides in Nagaland killed at least 115 people between April and August 14, 2026, disaster management officials in the two States said.

Many in Assam, including Sivasagar MLA Akhil Gogoi, blamed the unprecedented floods in Sivasagar and Charaideo districts on unregulated and unscientific sand, stone, and coal mining along the inter-State border. Excess water, accumulated in Nagaland’s coal pits, caused much of the damage in Assam, he said.

The TACMCA rejecting such theories, said, exceptionally heavy rainfall recorded in Nagaland on July 18, 2026 had led to unusually high water flow and triggered flash floods, particularly in Longleng, Mokochung, Mon, and Wokha districts.

Several interconnected factors can lead to extreme weather events, and the re-

cent disaster should not be attributed to one activity or community, it said, claiming that Nagaland had also suffered extensive damage from floods and landslides, although the focus was on Assam.

“Natural calamities do not recognise State boundaries or communities,” the association said, appealing to people in Assam and Nagaland to not point fingers at each other.

Accusations against an entire State, community, organisation, or group without established evidence could create divisions and cause further distress to people already affected by the disaster, the TACMCA said. It referred to the rivers, hills, forests, roads, and markets shared by the two States, and the social ties between Assam and Nagaland.

“We should help each other, understand each other, and stand together during adversities,” it said.

Facebook collective brings back charm of analogue cinema

M.P. Praveen  
KOCHI

Before digital files replaced film reels and online bookings replaced queues at ticket counters, going to the movies was an experience in itself. Theatre Diaries, a collective formed by people associated with movie theatres, is bringing a slice of that lost era back to life with an analogue screening of Rajinikanth’s *Baashha* in Kerala.

The 1995 Tamil blockbuster, which took Rajinikanth’s stardom to another level, was screened at Kripa theatre in Kurumassery in Ernakulam district on

August 5. The response to the first show has now prompted the collective to organise a repeat screening of *Baashha* at the same venue on August 16.

But the screening was about more than the superstar or the film. It was an attempt to recreate the movie-going experience of the pre-digital era and draw attention to a fast disappearing world of film reels, projectors and theatre jobs.

The organisers went all out to recreate the atmosphere of the mid-1990s. Though the screening was free, complimentary passes were distributed at the ticket counter,



A traditional projector that was used for the movie screening at Kripa theatre in Ernakulam district. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ter, with viewers queuing up to collect them. “We distributed complimentary passes through the ticket counter, where viewers queued up to collect

them,” said Arun Arvind, manager of Kripa theatre, and one of the 11 admins of the Facebook collective.

Then came another throwback. The film reel

was brought to the theatre on the back of a bicycle, a sight that would be unfamiliar to a generation used to digital projection. Theatre employees with decades of experience were also felicitated at the event, placing the spotlight on those who once kept the machines running and the shows going.

Theatre owner Anto Ilanjippilli made two analogue projectors available, one of which had to be restored with the help of a technician after days of work.

Interestingly, *Baashha* was not the collective’s first choice. Theatre Diar-

ies had wanted to screen a Malayalam film but could not find a good-quality reel. “We wanted to screen a Malayalam film but could not find a quality reel. In the analogue era, Malayalam films were mostly produced in Chennai, and original prints and negatives were often sold to labs and damaged due to lack of proper preservation,” said Prasob Nannammukku, one of the admins.

The collective plans to organise more programmes around the history of theatres and the technological changes that have reshaped the industry.



Govt. reduces export levy on petrol to nil; diesel, ATF cut

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

In their latest fortnightly review, the Union government cut the export duty on petrol to nil while reducing the levy on export of diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF) to ₹24 and ₹19.5 for every litre respectively.

There is no change in excise duty rates for petrol and diesel for domestic retail consumption.

Since the peak of the conflict in West Asia earlier this year, the Union government has been fortnightly reviewing export levies since March 27 to ensure domestic availability of the fuel by disincentivising exports.

In the previous fortnightly review, the Union government had increased the export levy on petrol to ₹3.5 per litre, diesel to ₹25.5 per litre and that on ATF to ₹22 per litre.

## Nyka Steel: NCLAT upholds order

Press Trust of India  
NEW DELHI

The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) upheld an order passed by the NCLT, directing insolvency proceedings against personal guarantor of Nyka Steel. It involves UCO Bank's IBC plea on Asif Ahmed Siddique.

# As Govt. mulls MDR on UPI, data shows cash usage quickening

An analysis by *The Hindu* shows that the growth in the value of UPI transactions has been consistently slowing since 2021-22, although the current rate of growth is still higher than that of cash with the public

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan  
NEW DELHI

At a time when the government is proposing to allow the levy of a charge on UPI transactions, an analysis shows that the growth in the value of UPI transactions has been slowing for the last five years, while the growth of cash with the public has been quickening over this period.

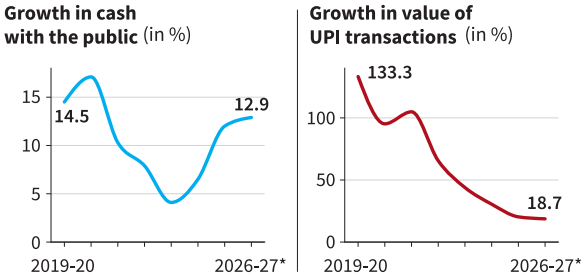
While slowing, the growth of UPI transactions remains faster than the growth of cash with the public, this margin is shrinking. Experts say this is both a sign of higher economic activity and also higher price levels than are being reflected in the official inflation data

UPI and RuPay debit card transactions are currently free, like cash transactions. However, the government passed the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026 in the recently-concluded Monsoon session of Parliament which enables it to allow a Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) charge to be levied on these electronic transactions.

**Cash is back**  
An analysis by *The Hindu* of data from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) shows that the growth rate of cash with the public reached a recent high of about 17% in the COVID-19 pandemic year of 2020-21.

## Cashing in

Even as the growth rate of UPI transactions has continued to fall, the growth of cash with the public has continued to accelerate



Source: RBI & NPCI | \*Note: Growth in cash with the public for 2026-27 is up to July 31, 2026 compared with the same period of the previous year. Growth in UPI transactions for 2026-27 is up to August 9, 2026 compared with the same period of the previous year.

**Opposition says the merchants who do have to pay the levy would pass on higher cost to customers**

Thereafter, the growth of cash with the public fell consistently until 2023-24, where it hit about 4%.

Cash with the public is the total cash in circulation minus what is sitting in banks.

Since then, the growth of cash with the public has been quickening. That is, this growth rate increased to 6.5% in 2024-25 and further to 12% in 2025-26.

In 2026-27, cash with the public, at ₹41.8 lakh crore as of July 31, 2026, was almost 13% higher than in the same period of the previous year.

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and the Payments Corporation of India have given assurances that the general public would not have to pay the MDR charge on UPI transactions and that it would only be levied on certain high value transactions.

However, the Opposition has said that the merchants who do have to pay this charge would pass on that higher cost to their customers in the form of higher prices and that this could push people back to using cash.

**UPI slowing but high**  
UPI transactions, on the other hand, have seen the growth slowing over the last few years, according to the data with the National Payments Corporation of

India (NPCI).

The value of UPI transactions conducted in the country increased by 133% in 2019-20, which then slowed to a relatively robust 95% in 2020-21 as the economy locked down.

It then quickened again to 105% in 2021-22 as the economy opened up and the pent-up demand combined with health fears over handling cash to push up UPI usage.

Since then, however, the growth in the value of transactions done on the UPI platform has consistently been slowing, with growth hitting 20.3% in 2025-26.

In 2026-27, this has further slowed to 18.7% as of August 2026, compared with the April-August period of last year.

However, this 18.7% growth in UPI transactions is still higher than the 13% growth in cash with the public in the same period.

**Inflation understated?**  
According to Pronab Sen, former Chief Statistician of the Government of India and former Chairman of the Standing Committee on Statistics, the fact that both cash and UPI transactions are growing should be manifesting in the form of higher inflation rates than what the official numbers are currently showing.

“This would imply that we are under-counting in-

flation, because that's where this should show up,” Mr. Sen told *The Hindu*. “If there is more money being transacted, both digitally and in cash, then that should show up in inflation. The first effect would be there.

“A lot of this could be explained if the official data showed prices were rising faster than they are,” he added.

The latest official retail inflation data for July 2026 stood at 4.45%, slightly higher than in June, while the wholesale data showed inflation had slowed marginally to 9.8% in July from 9.9% in June.

**Vibrant economy**  
D.K. Srivastava, chief policy advisor at EY India, says that simultaneous cash and UPI growth is a sign of a vibrant economy.

“The first reason is increasing economic activity in general,” Mr. Srivastava said. “That is to say, high growth rates. We have been maintaining a real growth rate in excess of 7% in the post-COVID years. That is the main reason why both cash transactions and digital transactions have increased.”

Mr. Sen, however, warned that an increase in the number of cash transactions could also point towards distress in the economy brought upon by high unemployment, especially among the youth.

# ‘Top 5 big family businesses hold over 60% income’

Ashokamithran T.  
MUMBAI

The top five big family businesses held over 60% of income share in corporate India in the past two decades even as liberalisation made markets more competitive, according to a study appearing in World Bank Economic Review.

The study titled “Business Groups, Concentration and Market Power in India” published in the World Bank Economic Review authored by Simon Commander, visiting professor at IE Business School, Madrid, Spain among other researchers from different universities, found that Reliance, Adani, Birla, Om Prakash Jindal and Tata Groups put together controlled over 60% of business revenue between 2001 and 2020.

Barring Birla Group, whose share in total gross revenue reduced steadily during the study period, the shares of other family businesses increased. Reliance and Adani Groups have consistently constituted at least 20% share in total income. The shares of Om Prakash Jindal and Tata Groups increased steadily but stayed at less than 10% of income shares.

**Concentration fell**  
The study acknowledges that the concentration in the market has reduced and as a result competitiveness has increased after liberalisation. This however has not prevented the



Top 25 family business groups constitute over 15% of the GDP.

large family business groups from dominating the market. The top 25 family business groups constitute more than 15% of the Gross Domestic Product-the value of goods and services sold in 2020, the study observed.

“The paper finds that market concentration has indeed been declining during that period, mainly due to policy-induced shrinkage of the public sector. Concentration has also been falling for the private sector and for the FBGs. Thus, at the NIC-3 level, the proportion of industries with low concentration has risen considerably over the period,” the authors observed. The largest five firms controlled more than half of the revenue in around 74% of NIC-3 industries, the study found.

NIC 3 refers to a Statistics Ministry classification of industries by specific sub sectors.

At the same time, family business groups have also diversified across different sectors, the study found.



**Little hope:** Prolonged uncertainty caused considerable anxiety, frustration and emotional distress, says Saluja. REUTERS

## Wipro's onboarding delay: IT rights body writes to Minister

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

The Nascent Information Technology Employees Senate (NITES), a Mumbai-based organisation working for the rights of IT employees, has sent a written complaint to Union Labour Minister Mansukh Mandaviya on the “prolonged and unexplained delay” in onboarding more than 200 students and young engineers selected by Wipro Ltd. under its Elite Hiring 2025 process.

Harpreet Singh Saluja, president of NITES and an advocate of the Bombay High Court, stated in the letter that the affected students and young engineers participated in Wipro's campus recruitment process on February 1, 2025, and cleared subsequent rounds in the same month.

Following interviews, they received offer letters on July 22, 2025, and ‘Letters of Intent’ in August 2025. “In December 2025, they reconfirmed interest through Wipro's official survey,” Mr. Saluja said, adding despite completing every requirement communicated by Wipro, these students and young engineers did not receive defi-

nite onboarding or joining date.

**Wipro's response**  
A Wipro spokesperson told *The Hindu* Wipro remained committed to onboarding the freshers, in line with its business requirements.

“We will continue to keep candidates informed on further updates,” the spokesperson added.

Mr. Saluja said, “The consequences are serious. These are young people at the beginning of professional careers who planned careers and financial commitments around the employment offered by Wipro. Many state that they declined or did not pursue other employment opportunities while awaiting onboarding.

“They and families have consequently faced continuing financial uncertainty and burdens relating to education, accommodation, daily expenses and family responsibilities. Prolonged uncertainty caused considerable anxiety, frustration and emotional distress.”

Mr. Saluja asked the Minister to initiate action at the earliest.  
(Inputs from Mini Tejaswi)

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD DN MANDALGARH  
Email.ID eemandalgarh.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in  
Court Road Mandalgarh Distt Bhilwara  
NIB CODE – PWD2627A2122  
Short Term Notice Inviting Bid- 10/2026-27  
Bids for Contract for Construction/Rehabilitation of Non Panchable/Missing Link Road Under Budget Announcement FY 2026-27 invited from interested bidders upto 20.08.2026 other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in) of the state the approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 1275.57 Lakh.  
NIB CODE – PWD2627A2122  
UBN No PWD2627WSOB09517, PWD2627WSOB09518 PWD2627WSOB09520 PWD2627WSOB09521 PWD2627WSOB09522 PWD2627WSOB09523  
(S.L.Bairwa)  
Executive Engineer  
PWD Dn Mandalgarh  
DIRPC/14563/2026 Email.ID semandalgarh.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग, ग्रामीण वृत्त जोधपुर  
क्रमांक: 1394 दिनांक: 07.08.2026  
अल्पकालीन निविदा सूचना संख्या : 05 वर्ष 2026-27  
NIB No. PWD2627A2075  
राजस्थान के राज्यपाल महोदय की ओर से विभिन्न सड़क का निर्माण कार्य हेतु उपयुक्त श्रेणी में सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग राजस्थान में पंजीकृत संवेदकों एवं राज्य सरकार/केन्द्र सरकार के अधिकृत संचालन/केन्द्रीय लोक निर्माण विभाग/राज्य स्तर पर संचालन विभाग/रेलवे इत्यादि में पंजीकृत संवेदकों, जो कि राजस्थान सरकार के उपयुक्त श्रेणी के संवेदकों के समकक्ष हों, से निर्धारित प्रपत्र में इंटेन्डरिंग प्रक्रिया हेतु ऑनलाईन निविदाएँ आमंत्रित की जाती हैं।  
निविदा से सम्बंधित विवरण वेब साईट http://dnr.rajasthan.gov.in व http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in व http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है। सम्पूर्ण निविदा प्रक्रिया http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in पर ऑनलाईन सम्पादित की जायेगी। कार्यवार पृथीयन संख्या निम्नानुसार है।  
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(डी आर माथवा)  
अधीक्षण अभियन्ता,  
स.मि.वि. ग्रामीण वृत्त, जोधपुर  
डीआईपीआर/सी/14436/26

कार्यालय अधीक्षापी अभियन्ता सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग स्वण्ड निम्बाहेड़ा  
Email ID - eenimbahera.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in दिनांक :- 06/08/2026  
क्रमांक :- विनिर्दिष्ट-10/26-27/607  
Notice Inviting Bid No 10/2026-27  
Bids For Construction of Various Class Room & Roads Under DMFT Scheme YEAR 2026-27 Procurement are invited from interested bidders upto 6.00 PM of 19.08.2026 Other particulars of the id may be visited on the procurement portal (http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in, http://sppp.raj.nic.in) of the state website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 396.51 Laes  
NIB CODE :- PWD2627A2050  
UBN CODE :-  
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2. PWD2627WSOB09039  
3. PWD2627WSOB09043  
4. PWD2627WSOB09045  
5. PWD2627WSOB09061  
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21. PWD2627WSOB09205  
22. PWD2627WSOB09214  
23. PWD2627WSOB09217  
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## ‘Despite reputation, India’s per-unit space launch cost highest’

The dependence matters because launch cost, the authors argue, is becoming a geopolitical issue: “SpaceX ... was responsible for 75% of global payload to orbit in 2025 ... going forward, it is not implausible that a U.S. administration might decide to weaponise this dependency or use it as a bargaining chip to coerce other nations.”

## SNAPSHOTS



## Webb spots unusual black hole at 'cosmic dawn'

Using the Webb telescope, astronomers have found a supermassive black hole existing just 660 million years after the Big Bang. The data indicated the object is enshrouded by a thick, dense envelope of hydrogen gas, suggesting it is growing rapidly. The team found the gas scattering light in a way that makes black holes appear heavier than they are, suggesting the masses of similar early black holes may have been overestimated by up to 100x.

# TB vaccine offers clue to shape immunity against Alzheimer's

# Google's AI advantage faces its biggest test yet



A photograph of three men sitting on a white, modern-style sofa. From left to right: a Black man in a dark suit and white shirt, a white man with glasses in a dark blue shirt, and a white man with curly hair in a light-colored jacket over a dark shirt. They are all looking towards the right side of the frame. The background consists of vertical panels in shades of blue and purple.

The real test is whether Google ships something in the next few quarters in coding, in agents, in whatever comes after chat that makes developers choose it first rather than as an alternative to Anthropic or OpenAI.



## Question Corner

# Feedback loops

This cycle takes more or less 24 hours, and takes the help of outside cues to adapt day to day. In particular, light-sensitive cells in the retina have a pigment called melanopsin that is sensitive to daylight and sends information directly to the SCN. So when you ‘experience’ daylight, the brain adjusts the timing of the SCN clock. Specifically, when daytime photons, which are rich in blue light, enter the retina, they ‘activate’ the cells containing melanopsin, which signal the SCN, which renders molecular changes in its clock machinery.

Readers may send their questions, answers to [science@thehindu.co.in](mailto:science@thehindu.co.in)



FAQ

What does Anthropic stand to gain and risk with its IPO?

What is Anthropic planning? Who does it compete with? What threat do Chinese and open source models pose? How could recursive learning decide the race?

Aroon Deep

**The story so far:** Anthropic is reportedly planning a \$2 trillion initial public offering (IPO) by September, according to a *Financial Times* report. Since the AI product Claude already rakes in billions of dollars, this would likely be a blockbuster IPO were it to be held today. Anthropic’s product is incredibly popular, with software engineers handing off increasingly large amounts of advanced coding work to agents built with the AI tool.

**Who does Anthropic compete with?** Along with Claude, ChatGPT and Codex continue to compete neck and neck with Anthropic’s tools. For coding-focused tasks and processes where AI tool use is needed, firms such as Cursor, recently acquired by SpaceX, could also pose a threat. And then there is the rapidly growing open source model ecosystem, where AI tools that can run on sufficiently advanced PCs are able to manage increasingly complex tasks just fine locally.

**What threat do Chinese and open source models pose?**

As corporates move through their experimentation and tighter budgets, firms extracting the highest reasoning from their models will attract the most investor interest

Anthropic faces significant risks in terms of the competition it faces both from other companies and countries. Fuelled by several years of research and capacity-building pushes, Chinese firms are gaining

ground on AI, with open source models like Alibaba’s Qwen shocking users with low hardware requirements and competitive performance.

So-called open source “harnesses,” which provide an interface for running the AI, have also emerged, like Bionic. These harnesses mimic the approachable interfaces of ChatGPT and Claude, even though they are – like all LLMs – just next-word prediction tools. If these tools get sufficiently advanced, the potential disruptions to subscription- and usage-based tools like Claude could be significant.

**Does Anthropic’s size protect it?** This is no reason to write off a firm as large as Anthropic. While size is no guarantee of success in entering the AI space – Microsoft, for instance, has had more luck in being an infrastructure platform for AI rather than an “inference” (AI query-response) provider on its own merit – there is a significant advantage for a company in having its AI tools being used widely.

Early stumbles by Google (whose Gemini model and other AI tools have caught up in the last few months) show that resources and AI lab size are no guarantee of dominance, especially when there is months of financing and reputational advantages to moving early.

**How could continual learning decide the race?**

The AI blogger Dwarkesh Patel said earlier this month that so-called continual learning, where an AI tool’s real world use is fed back into its training, could make a major difference in how good it is. “Right now, there are less than five prominent AI minds, and they are all quite similar to each other on account of being trained on roughly the same data,” Patel says. “But if AIs are learning from experience, and that experience is different between different AIs, we could see actually different AIs come out the other end.”

He adds, “When deployment becomes part of training, the returns to being ahead will accelerate. If you have the best model, and more people use your AI for more complicated and useful work, and give it lots of feedback that it can integrate beyond the session window, then your model will become even smarter.”

**What does RL mean for the IPO?** Since Claude’s models are not open source, those real world recursive learning gains would be significant, and give Anthropic pricing power. Then again, that is assuming that it leverages its current dominance to improve future models at a breathless pace, and assuming that open models and competitors don’t collectively erode its ability to self-improve in the coming months. A major focus of all the AI labs going forward is likely to be token cost, which is how much they charge enterprises for each unit of reasoning. As corporates move through their experimentation and controlling costs more (as they did with so-called finops for the cloud computing era), firms that are able to get the most reasoning out of their models, such as by leveraging more efficiency out of their tokens, will see the most investor interest.

Why has the Centre opposed creamy layer for SC/STs?

What did the Centre argue in the Supreme Court? What is the context for its position? What is sub-categorisation and what is the creamy layer concept? What is the Centre’s position on sub-categorisation? What could happen next in the Supreme Court?

Abhinav Lakshman

**The story so far:** Opposing a batch of petitions seeking a “creamy layer” exclusion from the reserved categories of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (like that for Other Backward Classes), the Union government recently reiterated in the Supreme Court of India that this concept of carving out exclusions within reserved categories was not applicable to the SC and ST classifications.

**What brought this about?** The current batch of petitions pending before the Supreme Court largely came through after a significant judgment of the top court in August 2024 (*Davinder Singh*), which recognised the “heterogeneity” of communities classified as SC and ST and the graded backwardness among the communities already in these constitutional lists. While doing so, a seven-judge Bench of the Court, headed by then Chief Justice of India, D.Y. Chandrachud, granted sanction to State governments to sub-categorise within the existing lists of SCs and STs to ensure that the benefits of reservations reach communities that have been routinely crowded out by relatively less backward communities within their respective lists.

However, in this judgment, Justice (Retd.) B.R. Gavai, in the opinion he had authored, noted that the problem of graded inequality and continued crowding out of certain SC/ST communities from benefits like reservations in public education and employment required that the government seriously start considering introducing a concept of “creamy layer” exclusions within these lists as well, as introduced for the OBCs in the landmark *Indra Sawhney* judgement (1992).

This particular observation had ignited protests from several SC and ST associations across the country, and the Union government and the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) were

Its opposition rests on the thinking that this would require exclusion of either certain communities or individuals from the benefit of reservation altogether – a power that the Social Justice Ministry has argued rests solely with Parliament

quick to take a strong position against the introduction of a creamy layer concept for SC and ST quotas. But this opened the door for petitions seeking orders that the Union government introduce this concept for SC/ST quotas as well, which prompted the Supreme Court to issue a notice to the Centre earlier this year. The Court also asked the Union government for a report on the action taken since the 2024 *Davinder Singh* judgment, intertwining sub-categorisation and creamy layer exclusion once again.

**What is the context for this position?** The most recent reiteration of the Union government in the Supreme Court against introducing the creamy layer exclusion for SC/ST quotas comes at a time when a significant section of students in the country (largely from the General Category) – traditionally been sympathetic to the ruling BJP establishment – have been participating in the Reservation Hatao Andolan (RHA). This a movement came into being through an Instagram page, soon after the countrywide student movement ignited by the Cockroach Janta Party led to the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the issue of the NEET paper leak. The RHA page on Instagram has garnered over 5 million followers and is being given direction by key actors of the anti-reservation movement such as Ajeet Bharti, Anuradha Twari, and Neha Das. All three have been consistently vocal for the rights of General Category students and job seekers and had also helped mobilise and amplify the protests against the UGC’s 2026 social equity rules earlier this year over alleged discrimination against General Category students. One of the principal demands of the RHA is to abolish all socio-economic caste reservation categories and only retain “income-based reservation”.

**What does graded inequality, sub-categorisation and creamy layer stand for?**

The idea of sub-categorisation is to divide an existing quantum of reservation for a single category to ensure access for unequal groupings within that category. The idea of a “creamy layer” exclusion is meant to identify individuals within a particular categorisation who may have escaped certain effects of discrimination or backwardness that their communities at large may still be facing, and then exclude them from availing themselves of reservation altogether. Both tools are aimed at restricting the crowding out of relatively more backward communities or individuals within a given category by relatively forward communities or individuals in that category.

**Where does creamy layer apply and where is sub-categorisation being done?** While the government has maintained that the

concept of creamy layer exclusions applied to OBC communities only, we could argue that the Economically Weaker Sections (EWS) reservation also embodies a similar idea. One criterion for availing this quota is that a person must not be eligible for any benefits meant for SCs, STs, or OBCs and must also belong to a family below a prescribed income and asset threshold. In this sense, the EWS framework also excludes those deemed economically better off, much like the creamy layer exclusion for OBCs, although the criteria and method of calculating income and assets are different.

The tool of sub-categorisation, however, has been more widely wielded – for SCs, STs, and OBCs – but more by State governments than by the Central government. The only arguable example of the Centre using sub-categorisation nationally has been within the ST category for admissions to Eklavya Model Residential Schools, where the ST quota is further divided to ensure minimum representation for Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups.

**What is the Centre’s position and rationale?** Even though the Union government is yet to make public its vision for using the sub-categorisation tool nationally for SC, ST, and OBC categories, its opposition to the introduction of the creamy layer concept in SC/ST quotas rests on the thinking that this would require exclusion of either certain communities or individuals from the benefit of reservation altogether – a power that the Social Justice Ministry has argued rests solely with Parliament. Further, it has argued that judicial precedent so far has never called for or suggested creamy layer exclusion for SC/ST.

Though it has taken this position in the ongoing cases before the top court, the Centre has notably left a potential roadmap for what it would take for it to consider such a move. It has said that such modifications to the reservation policy “should be preceded by a holistic review and thorough empirical study, including socio-economic data of reserved category beneficiaries” but stressed that it was not within the domain of the judiciary to direct it.

While the government has been clear about the classifications to which creamy layer exclusions would apply, it has been less emphatic about the scope of sub-categorisation. In its first term, the Modi government indicated that it was keen on sub-categorising OBCs nationally. The National Commission for Backward Classes recommended it in 2015, and the Centre formed the Justice (Retd.) G. Rohini Commission for this task in 2017. The report was submitted three ago years, but has not seen the light of day.

Similarly, when the issue of sub-categorisation of SCs was gaining prominence ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, both in the Supreme Court and in States such as Telangana and Andhra Pradesh, the Union government constituted an internal committee headed by the Cabinet Secretary to examine how the grievances of the Madigas could be addressed. But since the *Davinder Singh* judgment paved the way for sub-categorisation in principle, the Centre has remained silent on the issue.



Demonstrators take part in a Reservation Hatao Andolan rally in Nagpur, Maharashtra. PTI

Why has Bashar al-Assad been sentenced to death?

What are the charges against the former Syrian President, his brother, cousin, and others? Where are they right now? Why will it be difficult for the Shaara government to carry out the sentence? Why has Amnesty International expressed concerns over the judicial proceedings?

Vighnesh P. Venkitesh

**The story so far:** On August 11, the Fourth Criminal Court in Damascus sentenced Bashar al-Assad, who ruled Syria for more than two decades before being forced to flee amid a civil war in 2024, to death. Along with him, his brother Maher al-Assad, who commanded the notorious Fourth Division of the Army and was considered the regime’s top security official, cousin Atef Najib, and six others have also been sentenced.

While Najib is currently being in held in Syria and was present for the trials and ruling, the other eight were sentenced in absentia. The Assad brothers are currently under Russian asylum. The extradition of those sentenced in absentia, and the enforcement of their sentences, might be an arduous task for the present government under Ahmad al-Shaara, the former al-Qaeda operative with links to the Islamic State who, as Abu Muhammad al-Jolani, led the swift movement against the Assad regime in 2024 before taking over. However, the

Witnesses, underage during the Daraa uprising, testified in court about undergoing torture like beatings, electric shocks, suspension, and nail removal

sentencing could serve as a tool for political transition in the country.

**What are the charges against Bashar al-Assad and others?**

The judicial proceedings against the Assad brothers and their loyalists were the results of the efforts by the National Commission for Transitional Justice (NCTJ) set up by Mr. Shaara in May 2025 to investigate serious human right abuses during the “previous regime” and hold those responsible to account.

The Fourth Criminal Court in Damascus, presided over by Judge Fakhr al-Din al-Aryan, began trial of the ousted leader and others in April this year and convicted him, his brother, cousin, and the six others of murder, torture, unlawful deprivation of liberty, crimes against humanity, and war crimes.

The charges go back to the crackdown on the Daraa uprising in 2011. Protests were sparked by the detention and alleged torture of teenagers who drew anti-Assad graffiti on walls in Daraa. Demonstrations against this detention were met with a crackdown, which ignited nationwide movements and later led to instability in Syria. This opened the avenue for a civil war.

Witnesses, who were minors at the time of the uprising, recalled in court undergoing severe torture including beating, electric shocks, suspension, and nail removal. Some said Najib, who was then the head of political security in Daraa, personally interrogated them. The court held the ousted leader Assad responsible for a “joint criminal project”, saying that as President throughout the period covered by the case, including the years-long civil war that followed shortly after the uprising, he had power over state institutions. The former President was convicted for intentional murder of multiple people, intentional killing of children under 15, intentional killing accompanied by torture and brutality, and incitement to intentional murder



People celebrate after Atef Najib, a cousin of Bashar al-Assad, was sentenced to death for overseeing a crackdown in Daraa in 2011, in Damascus. AP

on multiple occasions.

**How is the administration planning to implement the sentence?**

The two Assad brothers live in Russia. The country previously denied extradition requests by the Shaara administration – it was a strong ally of Syria’s during the previous regime and helped it during the civil war against the U.S.-backed Kurdish group, Syrian Democratic Forces, and other militias. This is why the court and the administration will find it hard to carry out the sentence. However, the court has ordered arrest warrants against the “fugitives”, directing authorities to take necessary measures for their international prosecution. Following this, Syria’s Deputy Justice Minister Mustafa al-Qassem on August 12 announced the formation of a committee to seek the extradition of those convicted, saying that the panel would coordinate with Interpol to secure their handover.

**What are the concerns against in-absentia trials?**

Amnesty International has expressed concerns over the judicial proceedings, stressing shortly after the verdict was issued that trials and death sentences in absentia are incompatible with international standards of fair-trial guarantees. The sentencing of the Assad brothers and others followed the recent precedent set by Bangladesh, where ousted Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina was similarly sentenced to death in absentia for crimes against humanity, by the country’s International Crimes Tribunal in November last year.

Reacting to the proceedings in Syria, Amnesty noted that prosecuting those responsible for grave violations of human rights was key to achieving justice, but said that trials in absentia should be abolished if the Sharaa government wanted to “truly turn the page on the horrors of the past”. However, Syria’s Justice Ministry pushed back against the criticism, saying its statement “does not accurately reflect the nature of the judicial procedures followed in these cases or the safeguards guaranteed to litigants under Syrian law”.



PROFILES

India’s lunar future

Moon Base

NASA has invited ISRO to participate in its latest lunar programme, which seeks to build a human outpost near the Moon’s south pole, where sunlight is available for longer periods and permanently shadowed craters contain significant deposits of water ice

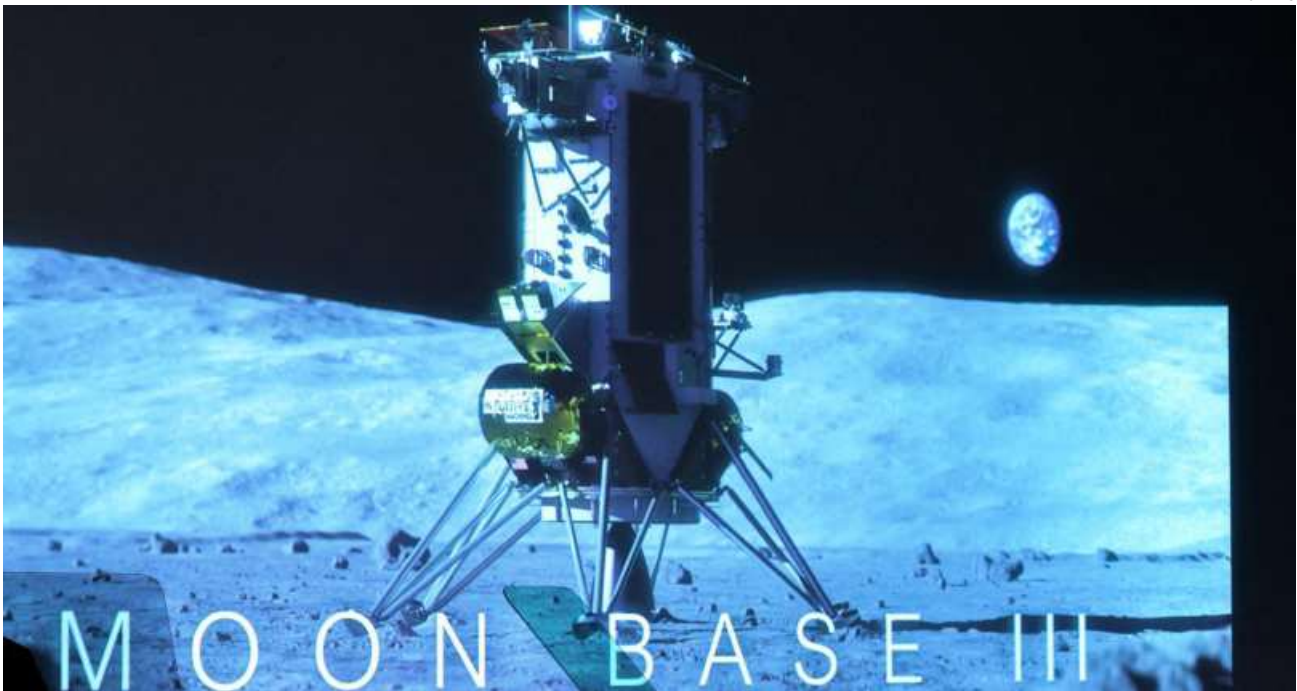
Vasudevan Mukunth

“The past is a foreign country; they do things differently there,” the English novelist L.P. Hartley wrote famously in his 1953 novel *The Go-Between*. In a peculiar twist, the same cannot be said of the Moon. It is not a foreign country, or even a foreign world: the U.S.’s manoeuvring to beat China to the satellite has increasingly meant the moon is an extension of the Earth’s geopolitics and political culture.

At the ninth India-U.S. Civil Space Joint Working Group meeting at Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) headquarters last week, NASA invited the organisation to participate in its ‘Moon Base’ programme, ostensibly as part of the two countries’ Artemis Accords partnership. According to NASA, the facility will be built piece by piece near the Moon’s south pole, where sunlight is available for longer durations and where permanently shadowed craters hold significant water-ice deposits. The target is for it to be humankind’s first outpost on a new celestial body, taking shape around 2030.

NASA is leaning heavily on private industry for this, having already awarded contracts to Astrolab (worth \$219 million) and Lunar Outpost (\$220 million) for lunar terrain vehicles, Blue Origin (\$188 million) for delivery task orders, and Astrobotic, Firefly Aerospace, and Intuitive Machines (\$600 million) for four robotic missions to the Moon to deliver equipment. Intuitive is also developing a relay satellite under a separate contract.

Further, as part of NASA chief Jared Isaacman’s overhaul of the Artemis programme earlier this year, in no small part responding to the Trump administration’s December 2025 space policy calling for securing U.S. interests in cislunar space, the profiles of the Artemis III and IV Missions changed. Now, Mission III will be a crewed test flight in Earth orbit in 2027 and Mission IV will attempt the first



REUTERS

lunar landing under the programme in 2028. Taken together, the ‘Moon Base’ is effectively the next phase of the new Artemis programme, tasked with keeping – intermittently at first, and eventually continuously – Artemis astronauts on the Moon.

Deepening partnership

Since India signed the Artemis Accords in 2023, NASA and ISRO have engaged regularly across several areas. NASA has trained India’s astronaut candidates for the ‘Gaganyaan’ human spaceflight mission. In 2025, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and U.S. President Donald Trump jointly announced a broader strategic technologies framework, including spaceflight.

ISRO also launched the NASA-ISRO Synthetic Aperture Radar, a major scientific mission that has been a decade in the making. NASA instruments are slated to fly on forthcoming Chandrayaan missions just as they did on the first three.

While it seems almost facile to suggest the U.S. also engage with China considering the latter’s formidable

spaceflight capabilities – many industry experts agree the age of U.S. dominance in spaceflight is in its twilight years – the two countries’ actions mean that the lines they have drawn on the Earth are set to be extended to the Moon, and that will pose new challenges for India.

In 2021, China and Russia announced plans to cooperate on an ‘International Lunar Research Station’ (ILRS), which China described as a long-term lunar science and technology facility, also to be built near the south pole and with a targeted deadline of 2035. Like the Artemis Accords, the ILRS is an international effort, currently involving 17 countries and organisations and more than 50 research institutions worldwide.

Earlier this year, when NASA solicited proposals for payloads to send to the Moon, it said it welcomed foreign entities “except those with bilateral ties to China”. NASA’s FY2027 budget request has also described the ‘Moon Base’ as a means to establish U.S. “superiority on the Moon” and to preserve U.S. leadership in space –

language with more strategic overtones relative to the agency’s pre-Trump rhetoric.

Given how much of U.S. policy is shaped by out-competing China, India’s gains or losses will not be restricted to its space programme either. For instance, ISRO’s engagement with NASA has arguably become more politicised thanks to NASA’s own politicisation by virtue of having to respond to China’s ILRS plans. Contrary to the focus areas of these bodies through much of their histories, future discussions would be poorly served by treating their engagement on the Moon as purely exploratory.

For example, the Artemis Accords do not say a signatory cannot cooperate with non-signatory countries. (In June, ISRO also hosted the BRICS Heads of Space Agencies meeting in Bengaluru with China among the participants). However, the Artemis programme itself is increasingly concerned with infrastructure, and building one’s components, equipment, tools, etc. to be interoperable with that

infrastructure will thus extend geopolitical alignments on the Earth to the Moon.

Suppose China invites India to join the ILRS in 2035. (In fact, the Moon could become one of the few domains in which India and China may have a practical incentive to cooperate on the Moon even while competing on the Earth, and India should endeavour to preserve rather than foreclose that possibility.) The government can say ‘yes’, but if China uses different communication protocols, data formats or operational procedures, India will face a tough choice: to build a second, expensive set of capabilities with China or to persuade China to change its systems to be interoperable with American designs.

Different ecosystems

That is, the U.S.-China competition means India’s increasing embedding in one technological ecosystem will also increase the cost of engaging with the other in future. At the same time, India will be mistaken to avoid deepening ISRO’s relationship with NASA. The U.S.-led ecosystem is much larger and more technologically diverse than the one led by China. But India may nonetheless have to reconsider its strategic autonomy in the spaceflight domain – particularly if the U.S.-China rivalry changes substantially over the next two or three decades. It should certainly steer clear of any dependencies that could hold back its own space programme because of U.S. objections.

In fact, one useful way to achieve this that also presents yet another opportunity for Indian leadership in space is to push for open international standards that allow nations to retain sovereign control over specific hardware and software components without hampering collaborations in space. Such diplomacy could foster interoperability between the lunar blocs and allow India to retain its strategic autonomy.

If it does not, the Moon may cease to be a foreign world but India may find itself a foreigner there.

THE GIST

NASA is leaning heavily on private industry for Moon Base, having already awarded contracts to Astrolab and Lunar Outpost for lunar terrain vehicles, Blue Origin for delivery task orders, and Astrobotic, Firefly Aerospace, and Intuitive Machines for robotic missions

Further, as part of then-new NASA chief Jared Isaacman’s overhaul of the Artemis programme earlier this year, the profiles of the Artemis III and IV Missions changed

Taken together, the ‘Moon Base’ is effectively the next phase of the new Artemis programme, tasked with keeping – intermittently at first, and eventually continuously – Artemis astronauts on the Moon.

The warrior tradition

Nihang Sikhs

The recent attack on the Akali Dal chief in Maharashtra has brought the community, traditionally regarded as ‘Guru’s army’, back to public attention

Lavpreet Kaur

They are difficult to miss. In electric-blue robes, with towering conical turbans rising above their heads and steel quoits, insignia and rosaries woven into them, Nihang Singhs move through a gathering with swords, spears and other traditional weapons hanging from their bodies. Their appearance is at once religious, martial and theatrical, but for the Nihangs, little of it is ornamental.

The community has returned to public attention after Shiromani Akali Dal president and former Punjab Deputy Chief Minister Sukhbir Singh Badal was attacked with a kirpan at the Mata Sahib Devan Ji Gurdwara in Nanded, Maharashtra, on August 13. The accused, identified as 62-year-old Jaspal Singh, had been serving at the gurdwara for two years and was described as a Nihang.

Nihangs were a conspicuous presence during the farmers’ agitation at Delhi’s Singhu border in 2020-21 and more recently at the student protest at Delhi’s Jantar Mantar in July 2026. Their presence, as much as their distinctive appearance, drew attention.

Their origin is associated with the creation of the Khalsa Panth by the 10th Sikh Guru, Gobind Singh, in 1699. Traditionally regarded as ‘Guru ki fauj’, or the Guru’s army, they re-



PTI

present the armed warrior tradition within Sikhism. The name Nihang is commonly associated with fearlessness and freedom from worldly attachment; another interpretation traces it to the Persian nahan, or crocodile, invoking the creature’s ferocity and toughness.

Historical roots

The tradition took shape in an age when Sikh communities faced repeated military persecution. Nihang warriors became mobile fighting groups, defending Sikh settlements and religious institutions against Mughal forces and, later, Afghan invaders. The martial tradition was subsequently woven into the military structures of the Sikh misls and the forces of Maharaja Ranjit Singh.

With the end of that era of warfare, their battlefield role gradually receded. But the discipline associated with it survived. Today, Nihangs are not a standing army. Their role is largely that of custodians and practitioners of a religious and martial tradition.

There is no single Nihang organisation representing the entire community. Historically divided into two broad dals, Baba Budha Dal and Taruna Dal – associated broadly with older and younger bands, respectively – both have since split into several factions. Researchers estimate there are more than 30 Nihang factions, large and small, in Punjab, making it difficult to arrive at a precise count of Nihangs. Their mobile and decentralised nature means there is no central command or membership registry.

A person wearing blue and carrying a weapon may look like a Nihang, but the traditional order demands considerably more: *bani* (wisdom) and *bana* (attire), spiritual practice and outward discipline, explained Varinder Walia, a former editor with a Punjabi daily and professor at Punjabi University in Patiala. Daily prayers and meditation, knowledge of Sikh scripture, observance of the Khalsa code, Shastar Vidya, the traditional study

and practice of Sikh weaponry, horse-riding, physical endurance and seva form part of the ideal.

Their tradition of movement and collective identity has also brought Nihangs into contemporary public life. Such appearances, historians suggest, need to be understood against the order’s decentralised structure: the presence or actions of one group or individual do not necessarily represent the Nihang community as a whole.

Nanded gives this story another layer. The city on the Godavari is home to Takht Sachkhand Sri Hazur Sahib, one of Sikhism’s five Takhts and the place where Guru Gobind Singh spent the final period of his life. The presence of a Nihang-managed gurdwara in the wider Hazur Sahib religious landscape is part of a much older institutional connection, even as the latest incident there has brought the community under renewed scrutiny.

The challenge in understanding the Nihangs today is to hold these two realities together. They are a living religious order, not a museum piece: their members pray, study scripture, serve food, care for horses and teach martial arts. At the same time, they carry a warrior vocabulary forged in an era when armed defence was central to Sikh survival. The battlefield may have changed, but the identity has endured.

The making of an agitator

Devendra Nath Mahto

The student leader has emerged as the most prominent face of the agitation over alleged irregularities in the conduct of exams in Jharkhand

Suruchi Kumari

On August 10, as thousands of Jharkhand students marched in the capital, Ranchi, to gherao the State Assembly, Devendra Nath Mahto appeared amid the crowd, held aloft by his supporters, with a framed photograph of former Jharkhand Chief Minister Shibu Soren in one hand and the other raised towards the protesters. Flower petals were showered on him as cameras and mobile phones followed his movements.

For a man who has spent a decade organising student protests, the attention is new only in scale. Mr. Mahto, 33, has emerged as the most prominent face of the agitation over alleged irregularities in the 14th Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) preliminary and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC) examinations. He has been on an indefinite hunger strike since August 2, and was hospitalised after the August 10 march.

The current agitation began days after the JPSC results were declared on July 2. A Jharkhand Loktantrik Krantikari Morcha (JLKM) leader, Mr. Mahto held a press conference on July 5, questioning the examination process, and submitted a set of demands to the Governor two days later. On July 8, protesters burnt an effigy

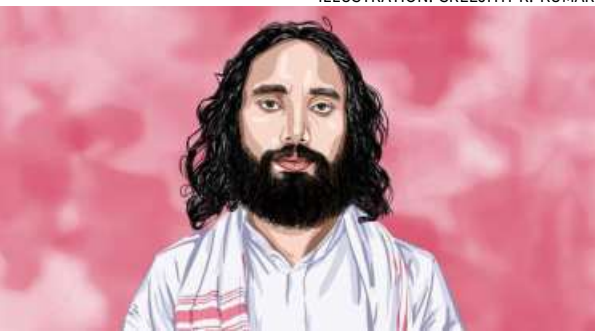


ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

of the JPSC chairman at Albert Ekka Chowk. After a meeting with Chief Minister Hemant Soren on July 20 yielded little, Mr. Mahto called for an indefinite sit-in at Babu Vatika in Morabadi on July 25, later moving to Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium.

The protest has since grown, with gheraos, marches and a continued hunger strike of at least six other students, even after three rounds of talks with the government that yielded in cancellation of JPSC prelims and backlog exams of 2023-25. However, Mr. Mahto says the protest will not be called off until all exams conducted by the TDPL (a private exam conducting agency) are cancelled, including JSSC-CGL, and CBI investigation is recommended.

A stage of students

Owing to his political affiliations, a section of students, days into the protest, set up a different station to keep their distance from “politics” and insisting that the stage remain independent of political parties.

Mr. Mahto responded by refusing to take the stage again when politics became a point of discussion. His bed was moved below the stage, as he affirmed, “This is the stage of students and their issues, not of any political party.”

There was little in Mr. Mahto’s early life to suggest a political career. Son of Vishambar Mahto, a retired government teacher, he grew up in Rahe village in Ranchi district. He was sent to Bundu, about 10 km from the village, for his matriculation and intermediate education. He later moved to Ranchi. He completed his B.Ed in Hazaribagh and postgraduate studies in Sanskrit and regional languages in Ranchi University till 2022.

“He wanted to be a teacher,” his brother said. “As any village child, he also wanted a simple government job to lead his life. That is why good education was prioritised.”

That changed in college. In 2016, Mr. Mahto began protesting over student scholarships. He subsequently became involved

in demonstrations over recruitment rules, paper leaks and alleged irregularities in JPSC and JSSC exams. According to friends, he has led around a dozen agitations since 2015.

The JLKM, founded by activist-politician Jairam Mahto, became a political vehicle, with Devendra Nath Mahto increasingly involved in its activities. He contested the 2024 Lok Sabha election independently from Ranchi and finished third, securing more than 1.4 lakh votes and then the 2025 Vidhan Sabha election from his home constituency Silli on the JLKM ticket.

The JLKM’s politics also includes the demand to extend Scheduled Tribe reservation to the Kudmi community, to which Mr. Mahto and Jairam Mahto belong. Yet, amid the current agitation, Mr. Mahto insists that his political identity must not eclipse the issue that brought him there.

“This is not my voice. This is the voice of lakhs of aspirants who have been affected, and their mothers who await a better future,” he said. “I knew this movement would grow bigger because this is a student movement.” For now, he says, he will remain on hunger strike. “The government has given us nothing in writing. How can I end my strike until the students are satisfied with the government’s response?” he asked.



TEHRAN

Iran calls for release of pilots held in Qatar during the West Asia war



Iranian authorities on Saturday called for the release of three pilots they say were captured in Qatar during the West Asia war. "Three Iranian pilots were captured alive by Qatari forces after their Su-24 fighter jets crashed," said General Mohammad Bagherzadeh of the Iranian armed forces, *Fars* news agency reported. AFP

SANAA

Houthi missiles kill at least four civilians in port city, says Yemen



Yemen's internationally recognised government said the Houthis fired six ballistic missiles at the Red Sea port of Mocha on Friday, killing four civilians, amid an escalation in hostilities between the Iran-aligned group and its Saudi-backed opponents. The Houthis said they had attacked "Saudi-backed military build-ups". AP

SEOUL

South Korea proposes talks with North to formally end Korean War



South Korean President Lee Jae Myung proposed talks with North Korea to formally end the long-running Korean War, as Pyongyang deepens ties with Russia while asserting its status as a nuclear state. The two Koreas remain technically at war since their 1950-53 conflict ended with an armistice rather than a peace treaty. AFP

BANGKOK

Over 300,000 Rohingya refugees verified for repatriation: Myanmar



Myanmar's military-backed government said on Saturday that more than 300,000 Rohingya refugees living in camps in Bangladesh are former residents of western Rakhine state and that it will accept their return once security conditions improve. The statement comes as the Rohingya refugee crisis enters its ninth year. AP

Iran fires back at Trump's threat to declare Hormuz a U.S. territory

The waterway is and will remain Iranian, the Islamic republic's officials say in response to Trump's claim; the strait will only be closed and opened under Iran's command, says Gharibabadi; UAE says one of its ADNOC vessels came under attack

Agence France-Presse  
TEHRAN

Iran on Saturday fired back at U.S. President Donald Trump's claim that he would soon declare the Strait of Hormuz part of U.S. territory, saying the crucial energy waterway it has blockaded "will remain Iranian".

Mr. Trump has repeatedly said the strait, which Tehran effectively closed at the start of the West Asia war in late February, is under U.S. control – an assertion the Islamic republic denies.

"The Strait of Hormuz has been Iranian, is Iranian, and will remain Iranian," Iranian Deputy Fo-



**Critical passage:** Vessels are seen in the Strait of Hormuz, off the port city of Bandar Abbas in southern Iran on August 10. AFP

reign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi said on X. "This strait will only be closed and opened under Iran's command."

Mr. Trump told a political rally in New York state

on Friday that after the U.S. defeats Iran, "pretty soon I'll be declaring the Hormuz Strait a territory of the United States". "It's true," he added.

An unnamed White

House official later clarified that Mr. Trump was joking, the *Wall Street Journal* reported.

List of conditions

Last week, a top Iranian official laid out a laundry list of conditions for reopening the strait, including an end to the "war and aggression against Iran and its allies in Lebanon, Palestine, Yemen, and Iraq".

Mohammad Bagher Zolqadr also demanded the end of crippling sanctions, the release of frozen assets and compensation for war-time damage.

As diplomacy stalls between the decades-long foes, attacks in the Hormuz strait have continued,

highlighting the continued risks to regional shipping.

United Arab Emirates' state-owned oil giant ADNOC said on Saturday that one of its vessels came under attack the night before.

On Friday, the Gulf nation blamed Iran for other attacks on two vessels linked to ADNOC as they passed through the strait.

Such attacks led to the collapse of an April ceasefire between the United States and Iran.

As Iran throttles traffic in Hormuz, its Houthi allies in Yemen have also declared a parallel maritime blockade on Saudi ports in the Red Sea, the oil-exporting giant's only other maritime route.

Ukraine attacks Russia's Samara industrial site

Associated Press  
KYIV

A large-scale Ukrainian attack struck industrial infrastructure in Russia's southwestern Samara region on Saturday, a Russian official said.

Ivan Noskov, head of the region's capital, Samara, said air defence forces had repelled a "massive" missile attack, with "localised damage" to the city's industrial sites. He also said that medical assistance has been provided to those injured in the attack, but did not give further details.

Ukraine has stepped up its long-range aerial attacks on Russian military industries and energy facilities, aiming to cut Moscow's revenue for the war and make Russians feel the consequences of the invasion, now in its fifth year.



A file photo of Vladimir Putin during a visit to the Progress Centre in Samara region in southwestern Russia. REUTERS

Writing on social media, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said that Kyiv's forces had carried out a strike against Samara's Progress Centre, which operates under Russian space agency Roscosmos and is involved in producing rocket technology and electronics.

He said that the strike used Ukraine's domestically produced Flamingo mis-

siles to hit the site, which is approximately 900 km from the Ukrainian border. Mr. Zelenskyy also said Russia's Savasleyka air base, some 700 km from the front line, had also been hit.

Russia's Ministry of Defence said that it had shot down 598 Ukrainian drones over 19 Russian regions, as well as the Black and Azov Seas and Crimea.

Israeli air strikes on southern Lebanon kill at least 11 people

Associated Press  
BEIRUT

Israeli air strikes on southern Lebanon killed at least 11 people Saturday, in the deadliest attacks since a precarious truce between Israel and Hezbollah went into effect on June 20.

Lebanon's Health Ministry and state news agency said one of the air strikes that targeted a home on the edge of the village of Ansar killed seven people, including three children, and wounded two. The se-

cond, on the village of Deir al-Zahrani, killed four and wounded 17.

Lebanese Prime Minister Nawaf Salam criticised Israel's air strikes, saying they undermine efforts to stabilise the situation.

The Israeli military said that it struck Hezbollah infrastructure in response to an action against Israeli soldiers in the area. It added that it will not allow the Hezbollah to harm Israeli civilians or soldiers "and will continue to operate to remove threats".

Supporters hold street rallies as Taliban regime marks 5 years ruling Afghanistan

Agence France-Presse  
KABUL

The Taliban regime celebrated five years of ruling Afghanistan on Saturday, with supporters taking to the streets, while critics decried tightening restrictions in all areas of daily life.

Afghans packed into cars decorated with flags and drove around Kabul on a day that regime spokesperson Zabihullah Mujahid said "will be written in golden lines in the history of Afghanistan".

Hundreds gathered



Afghan youth ride a military vehicle during celebrations to mark the fifth anniversary of Taliban's return to power, on Saturday. AFP

around a square beside the former U.S. embassy, while fresh flowers were thrown from military helicopters over a parade of athletes

that featured only men because women are banned from sport in Afghanistan.

Taliban fighters took Kabul unopposed on August

15, 2021, after a lightning offensive that swept across Afghanistan, toppling government forces in the wake of the chaotic withdrawal of U.S.-led troops.

Although Taliban officials have forged ties with multiple countries, including in Europe, their government is still only recognised by Russia.

Some countries have opted to limit their relations with the Taliban authorities until there are changes in Afghanistan, where people are suffering "very real harm" according to the United Nations.

Magnitude 7.7 quake strikes off Indonesia's coast, kills at least 40

Associated Press  
MAUMERE

A powerful magnitude 7.7 earthquake struck off the coast of Indonesia early Saturday, killing at least 40 people, collapsing buildings and causing panic in a region prone to deadly quakes. Authorities said dozens of residents were injured.

Authorities issued a tsunami warning and urged coastal residents to move to higher ground, but later lifted the warning when In-

donesia's meteorological agency said monitoring showed no significant sea-level changes that would pose a threat to coastal communities.

East Nusa Tenggara Police Chief Rudi Darmoko said the earthquake caused severe damage and collapsed buildings. He said power outages in cities and villages have complicated rescue efforts.

The toll could rise as landslides triggered by the earthquake buried or cut off many remote villages.

Sport

Petronas TVS Racing's Sarthak snatches a late victory

MOTORSPORTS

Sports Bureau  
CHENNAI

Sarthak Chavan, 19, snatched a dramatic victory with a last-lap move, leading a 1-2 finish for Petronas TVS Racing team in the Super Sport 301-400cc race to launch his campaign on a bright note in the MRF Indian National Racing Challenge 2W-2026 at the Madras International Circuit here on Saturday.

Ann Jennifer (Motul Sparks Racing) dominated the Super Stock 165cc Intermediate field for a fine win while Allwin Xavier (RACR Castrol Power1) took the honours in the Super Stock 301-400cc Open class.

Both categories were run concurrently.



**Fast and furious:** Sarthak on the way to winning the Super Sport 301-400cc race. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Savion Sabu (Madrabbit Racing) rode a mature race for a superb win in the Pro Stock 200cc class, moving up from sixth while Hari

Haran (RACR Castrol Power1) emerged triumphant in the Stock 165cc (Novice) category. R. Ashwin, a private entrant, topped the

Stock 301-400cc (Novice) race that went down to the wire.

**Provisional results (all 6 laps): Super Sport 301-400cc (Race-1):** 1. Sarthak Chavan (Petronas TVS Racing) (11min, 01.971secs); 2. Chiranth Vishwanath (Petronas TVS Racing) (11:02.264); 3. Rahil Pillarisetty (RACR Castrol Power1) (11:02.609).

**Super Stock 301-400cc Open (Race-1):** 1. Allwin Xavier (RACR Castrol Power1) (11:41.198); 2. Seshadri (Motul Gusto Racing) (11:41.824); 3. Kamal Navas (Team Rockers Racing) (11:42.805).

**Super Stock 165cc Intermediate (Race-1):** 1. Ann Jennifer AS (Motul Sparks Racing) (12:48.559); 2. M. Ajai Xavier (Ipone Yakuza Racing India) (12:51.139); 3. S. Anand Kumar (Ipone Yakuza Racing India) (12:55.914).

**Pro-Stock 200cc Open (Race-1):** 1. Savion Sabu (Madrabbit Racing) (11:54.910); 2. R.S. Abdul Basim (Chandra LGE

Racing) (11:55.619); 3. Senthil Kumar (Team Rockers Racing) (11:55.666).

**Stock 130-16cc (Novice) (Race-1):** 1. R. Hari Haran (RACR Castrol Power1) (13:11.711); 2. Yashwant Varma (Motul Sparks Racing) (13:12.286); 3. Faruk Ali Sohtun (Motul Sparks Racing) (13:12.483).

**Stock 301-400cc Novice (Race-1):** 1. R. Ashwin (Pvt.) (12:19.448); 2. G Balaji (VEEDOL C2 Racing) (12:19.498); 3. Aaron Joseph (RACR Castrol Power1) (12:39.529).

**Petronas TVS Racing One-Make Championship:** Open (RR 310) (Race-1): 1. Rajender Beedani (11:46.679); 2. R. Hari Haran (11:47.751); 3. Manoj Yesuadiyan (11:53.767).

**Women (Apache RTR 200) (Race-1), 5 laps:** 1. Poojita Anil Kumar (11:28.499); 2. Drishya Nair (11:35.942); 3. Kinjal Raj (11:42.814).

**Rookie (Apache RTR 200) (Race-1):** 1. Pothu Vignesh (13:16.496); 2. Rehbar Islam Baktoo (13:17.396); 3. C. Godwin Clarence (13:22.991).

**HYDERABAD:** The three-year-old colt Bulletproof, who won the Mysore Colts Trial in his last start, should score an encore in the K. Mahipathi Rao Memorial Golconda Juvenile Million, the feature event of Sunday's races.

**1. RAZIA SULTANA PLATE** (1,600m), (terms) Maiden 3-y-o only (Cat. II), 1-20 p.m.: 1. Master Class (5) Gaurav 56, 2. Smashing Grey (3) Afroz K 56, 3. Twilight King (4) P. Ajeeth K 56, 4. Vidyut-prabhava (1) M.S. Deora 56, 5. Aakarshaka (7) Md. Ismail 54.5, 6. Grit 'N' Grace (8) Shivam 54.5, 7. Ruby Tuesday (6) Arjun 54.5 and 8. Velvera (2) Trevor 54.5.

**2. LOYAL MANZAR PLATE** (1,600m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. II), 2-00: 1. Bholi Punjaban (3) Surya Prakash 60.5, 2. Black Dust (6) P. Sai K 59.5, 3. Wolf Creek (5) Ashad Asbar 58, 4. Authoritarian (2) G. Naresh 55, 5. Pristine Glory (8) Trevor 52.5, 6. Special Star (7) Ajay K 51.5, 7. Hoping Star (1) Arjun 51 and 8. La Fleur-iere (4) Kuldeep Jr. 50.

**1. PRISTINE GLORY, 2. WOLF CREEK, 3. AUTHORITARIAN.**

**3. INDEPENDENCE TROPHY** (1,100m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. IB), 2-40: 1. Star Of Opera (10) Shivam 61.5, 2. Kalki (12) Kuldeep Jr. 59.5, 3. See The Light (3) Trevor 59, 4. Rival (4) P. Sai K 58, 5. Diligence (5) Kuldeep Sr.

57, 6. N R I Range (9) G. Naresh 56.5, 7. Sharanga (8) Abhay Singh 56.5, 8. Dashing Charm (1) P. Ajeeth K 55.5, 9. Dontblockmyway (7) Afroz K 55.5, 10. Vital Sign (6) B.R. Kumar 55.5, 11. First Lady (2) B. Nikhil 51.5 and 12. Lazarus (11) Surya Prakash 51.5.

**4. VETERINARY AND ANIMAL HUSBANDRY DEPARTMENT TROPHY** (1,400m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III) (No Whips), 3-20: 1. Knotty Senorita (1) Md. Ekram 60.5, 2. Suryavanshi (9) Kuldeep Jr. 60.5, 3. Onslaught (4) Md. Ismail 60, 4. Gold Touch (8) Kuldeep Sr. 59.5, 5. Real Thalaviva (6) Mohit 58.5, 6. Super Splash (11) P. Ajeeth K 58.5, 7. Photograph (2) G. Naresh 55.5, 8. Aquatone (10) A.A. Vikrant 55, 9. Dhanadeepa (3) B. Nikhil 54.5, 10. Marissa (7) Surya Prakash 515, 11. Quality Warrior (5) Santosh 51.5 and 12. The Divinely (12) Rafique Sk. 51.

**5. K. MAHIPATHI RAO MEMORIAL GOLCONDA JUVENILE MILLION** (1,400m), (Terms) 3-y-o only, 4-00: 1. Advait (8) Shivam 56, 2. Buddy (7) D.S. Deora 56, 3. Bulletproof (9) Trevor 56, 4. Cosmic Gift (2) Kuldeep Sr. 56, 5. Divine Tiger (4) P. Ajeeth K 56, 6. Eminent Gold (1) P. Sai K 56, 7. Garfinkle (10) Ashad Asbar 56, 8. My Way (My) Rules (3) Afroz K 56, 9. Yali (5) Gaurav 56 and 10. Quattro (6) B.R. Kumar 54.5.

**1. BULLETPROOF, 2. DIVINE TIGER, 3. BUDDY.**

**6. GRAND PARADE PLATE** (1,600m), 5-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 4-40: 1. Miss Marvellous (7) G. Naresh 60, 2. Mountain Touch (4) Trevor 60, 3. Sargent (6) I. Chisty 58, 4. Take A Breath (11) Rafique Sk. 58, 5. Silver Arrow (3) A.A. Vikrant 57.5, 6. N R I Star (9) Afroz K 54.5, 7. Natu Natu (10) Gaurav 54.5, 8. Sadiya (8) P. Ajeeth K 54, 9. Shubhrah (1) Kuldeep Jr. 53.5, 10. Exclusive Luck (5) B. Nikhil 52.5 and 11. Bold Indian (2) P. Sai K 51.5.

**1. MOUNTAIN TOUCH, 2. EXCLUSIVE LUCK, 3. SILVER ARROW.** Day's Best: PRISTINE GLORY. Jackpot: 2, 3, 4, 5 & 6. Mini Jackpot: 3, 4, 5 & 6. Treble: (i) 1, 2 & 3, (ii) 4, 5 & 6. Tanala: All races.

**LIVE TELECAST**

**Sri Lanka vs. India:** First Test, Day 2, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 9.45 a.m.

**Hockey World Cup:** Women, Star Sports Select 2, Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 1.30 p.m.; China vs India, 4.30 p.m.; 9 p.m. & 12 a.m. (Monday); Men, 3, 6, 7.30 & 10.30 p.m.

**Durand Cup:** Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 4 & 7 p.m.

**LaLiga:** FanCode, 8.30 & 10.30 p.m.

A NO-NDE



MEMORABLE OCCASION

Padikkal first Indian to score a Test hundred on Independence Day



PTI

Devdutt Padikkal became the first Indian to score a Test century on Independence Day. The left-hander notched up his maiden hundred in the longest format against Sri Lanka on the opening day of the Galle Test on Saturday. It was the 26-year-old's third Test and his first one in nearly 21 months.

WELCOME NEWS

Rahul looks absolutely fine and should be good to play: Kotak



ANI

India's batting coach Sitanshu Kotak stressed that K.L. Rahul is on the recovery path. "KL batted really well. He got cramps and once you start getting it, you get it in the hamstring, you get it in the groin... he was also getting cramps in his hand. But at the moment he looks absolutely fine, and he should be good to play".

POSITIVE OUTLOOK

Debutant Nuwantha created chances but wasn't lucky: Gregory



PTI

Sri Lanka's fielding coach Jordan Gregory lauded off-spinner Keshara Nuwantha. "As a debutant, you are bound to have some nerves but Nuwantha did well. He bowled long spells and did create some chances but wasn't lucky. We see his emergence as a positive. Prabath Jayasuriya, too, has an excellent average at Galle".

PARTNERSHIP

Coe urges LA28 organisers to work closely with the US government



AFF

Sebastian Coe is urging LA28 organisers to work as closely with government as he did. Coe says the organisers of the LA Olympics will have to accept working shoulder-to-shoulder with the US administration. "The balance is keeping the politicians on the bus, but not letting them anywhere near the steering wheel," said Coe.

Padikkal's maiden Test century puts India in control on the opening day

The left-hander adds 150 with Rahul for the second wicket before the latter retires hurt on 77; opener Jaiswal's promising innings cut short after a mix-up; Prabath, the lone successful bowler for the home side; only 73 overs possible as rain interrupts play at the Galle International Stadium



Standing tall: Padikkal grabbed the chance to bat at No. 3 with both hands. PTI

INDIA IN SRI LANKA

K.C. Vijaya Kumar  
GALLE

A leap in the air, a clenching of fists, a mild fumble to remove the helmet and then Devdutt Padikkal raised his bat. India's No. 3 batter, a slot he got after injury benched Sai Sudharsan, had his moment under the sun at the Galle International Stadium here on Saturday.

Padikkal's maiden Test century (131 batting, 178b, 12x4, 1x6) and his earlier unfinished 150-run second-wicket partnership with Karnataka Statemate K.L. Rahul helped India post 288 for two against Sri Lanka on the opening day of the first Test. At close, an aggressive Rishabh Pant (27 batting, 36b, 3x4, 1x6) was giving company to Padikkal.

**Poise and panache**  
Through a day that wavered between the sun's oppressive heat and dark clouds bequeathing rains, the one consistent factor was the poise and panache that Padikkal revealed. Walking in after an unfortunate mix-up caused Yashasvi Jaiswal's run out, Padikkal remained positive and helped Rahul get over his guilt-trip. The two forged an alliance with an ease like two Bengaluru lads tucking into apple-crumble and cream at Corner House, back home. A six off left-arm spinner

SCOREBOARD

INDIA — 1ST INNINGS

Yashasvi Jaiswal run out 32 (37b, 5x4), K.L. Rahul ret'd. hurt 77 (162b, 9x4, 1x6), Devdutt Padikkal (batting) 131 (178b, 12x4, 1x6), Shubman Gill c Udara b Prabath 16 (28b, 2x4), Rishabh Pant (batting) 27 (36b, 3x4, 1x6); Extras (lb-2, nb-3); 5; Total (for two wkts. in 73 overs): 288.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-47 (Jaiswal, 10.6 overs), 2-236 (Gill, 61.5).

SRI LANKA BOWLING

Asitha 10-1-28-0, Kumara 10-1-51-0, Nuwantha 21-0-98-0, Prabath 24-4-77-1, Dhananjaya 4-0-15-0, Dinusha 4-0-17-0.

**Toss:** India.

Prabath Jayasuriya whetted Padikkal's appetite and the shot found an echo from Rahul's bat too. Padikkal then whipped debutant off-spinner Keshara Nuwantha past the ropes and India had a lunch score of 101 for one. As if on cue, the skies opened up and the players were forced to stay indoors till 2 p.m.

In the afternoon session, Padikkal and then Rahul got to their respective fifties. The host spinners at times erred with their line and length and if southpaw Padikkal was quick to cut, Rahul preferred the slow-violence of dabs and glides as India moved to 197 for one at tea. The latter, though, suffered cramps and had to retire hurt on 77 (162b, 9x4, 1x6) in the last session.

Skipper Shubman Gill soon essayed cover drives of the highest beauty but perished while playing against the turn off Prabath.

A sudden burst of rain paused the game again and when play resumed, Padikkal was around to offer assurance.

Earlier in the morning, under bright skies, Gill

won the toss and elected to bat. The decision found immediate validation through the manner in which Rahul and Jaiswal batted.

Rahul bided his time and Jaiswal was alert to scoring opportunities. In the very first over bowled by Asitha Fernando, Jaiswal whipped a four.

From the other end under the ramparts of the Dutch fort, Lahiru Kumara tried to bounce Rahul and the latter pulled a four.

Jaiswal drove on either side against Kumara and as the openers coasted, Sri Lankan captain Dhananjaya de Silva employed spin after eight overs. And then against the run of play, a run out stymied the Indians.

Rahul punched Nuwantha down the ground and instinctively set off for a single. A hesitant Jaiswal got entangled with the bowler and by then the throw was in and wicket-keeper Niroshan Dickwella dislodged the bails.

A worried Rahul slowed down a bit before Padikkal's flair seeped into the senior partner, and Indian cricket breathed easy on Independence Day.



Man for all seasons: Kotak lauded Rahul's adaptability. PTI

Padikkal's style of play pleases Kotak

K.C. Vijaya Kumar  
GALLE

Hopping across the Palk Strait, Devdutt Padikkal has found his groove. In the warm-up fixture at Colombo, he cracked an unbeaten 142, and once he moved to Sri Lanka's southern coast, a splendid maiden Test hundred was essayed. "I am so happy for him. He was waiting for this opportunity and the way he played was really encouraging," India's batting coach Sitanshu Kotak said.

Talking to the media after the opening day of the first Test here on Saturday, Kotak offered his appraisal about Padikkal. "When I was at the NCA, he was working on his initial movement, he also worked on his back-foot game. When we expect there will be turn, we try and work on stepping out, sweep or back-foot game. A lot of credit goes to him."

Asked specifically if Padikkal's ton has erased India's worries over the No. 3 slot, Kotak said: "He batted well, Sai (Sudharsan), too, has batted well at that number. But the thing is they are all new batters. We are flexible in a way. Mainly I would look at the way they bat, about how they are adapting to condi-

tions, how they are dealing with the different stages. How they bat is important to me more than the number they bat at."

**Dry surface**  
Kotak termed the pitch as dry and explained: "When we saw the wicket, we felt that it is on the drier side. And there is no doubt that it is on the drier side. 288 for two is a good sign for us but it is just one day and we have a long way to go. I don't think it will crack but I think it will spin more as the game progresses. The overall record shows that as the game progresses (at Galle), the average return of the batters goes down noticeably."  
K.L. Rahul's adaptability was also lauded and Kotak said: "In Tests he opens, in limited overs cricket he comes in at five or six. He is flexible that way and in a young team when a senior like him plays well, it always helps. He takes responsibility, builds partnerships and is consistent."  
And as for Yashasvi Jaiswal's run out, Kotak clarified: "It is just that KL stopped halfway. Jaiswal got up and took one step. And that's why probably that misunderstanding happened. But these things happen and it is unfortunate".

Chinese shuttlers no longer the dominant force in racquet sport

India's home-court intensity the talking point at the Worlds

BADMINTON

Uthra Ganesan  
NEW DELHI

The Chinese aura is diminishing.

For a formidable machine that churned out winners like clockwork and has had an incredible 72 champions, Shi Yuqi is the only one who will go into the upcoming badminton World championships looking to defend his title.

Shi's win in Paris last year ended a 10-year barren streak, the previous winner being Chen Long in 2015.

Among the women, the drought has been much longer. Yihan Wang was the last Chinese to win the title way back in 2011. No wonder, most of the queries to the ones here revolved around the pres-



Odd man out: Shi is the only Chinese player coming in as the defending champion. AFP

sure of expectations. "The players of China are very good and large in number. We don't have pressure of performance as such; it is more about learning from each other and it benefits everyone," World No. 9 Li Shifeng said on Saturday. It's a recurrent theme – the power of numbers, the

insistence on lack of pressure and self-belief. But there is no denying the fact that the rest of the world has successfully ended the Chinese chokehold on the sport. Consider this: China has three women in the top 10 but only two more in top 100. The men fare better, numerically; six in top 50

and eight in top 100.

Chen Yufei has come the closest to breaking the jinx, reaching the World championships finals in two of the last three editions but going down to Akane Yamaguchi both times, including last year. Her most recent outing, at the China Open, again ended in a straight games loss to Yamaguchi.

"I think it is more about ourselves, how we prepare. There is no pressure, only an expectation to do our best.

"You just need to have faith in yourself and not care about anything else. My biggest obstacle is myself and if I can conquer that, I believe I can win gold," Yufei said about the missing title in her cabinet.

The red shirts on court are always intimidating. For now, though, the pressure is on them.

Devvanshi Bihani  
NEW DELHI

The badminton World championships will begin here on Monday, with the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium already buzzing with activity as players sweated it out in their final practice sessions.

The tournament, which runs until August 23, marks the return of the event to India for the first time since 2009.

"I feel like the drift... the weather, everything is very well maintained and very good as compared to last time," said World No. 2 Wang Zhiyi. She added that the focus over the last few days had been on training rather than obsessing over opponents.

Former Olympic champion Chen Yufei was still not fully fit after retiring injured against P.V. Sindhu at



Practice buzz: The players brought high energy while training at the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium. DEVYANSHI BIHANI

the Japan Open, allowing the Indian to reach her first final in more than two years. "It's better than the last match but I think it's not 100%," she said.

Chen played down preparing for any one rival, saying she would focus on each match. That approach could be tested later in the tournament

against An Se-young, with whom she has been battling since 2018. The head-to-head is 14-17 now. Sindhu has also proved a particularly difficult opponent for Chinese players at the World championships.

Liang Weikeng and Wang Chang are still chasing their first crown, having won bronze in 2023.

They spoke of the importance of playing together, saying they "motivate each other" and quickly move on after mistakes.

Their history with Satwicksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty makes the potential quarterfinal intriguing. The Liang-Wang duo had won four straight times against them before the Indians finally won in Paris last year, only for the Chinese pair to respond with a victory at the World Tour Finals.

On the practice courts, the intensity was evident. Sat-Chi sparred with M.R. Arjun and Hariharan Am-sakaranun while Tanisha Crasto and Dhruv Kapila trained alongside Rohan Kapoor and Ruthvika Gadde. Sindhu and Ayush Shetty traded attacking exchanges, with coach Ir-wansyah Adi Pratama watching on.









**Nature's palette:** Sappan heartwood, a natural source of pigment, used to make paint.



**Getting it right:** Sappan heartwood is boiled in water to extract its natural pigment, which is later used to prepare paint for the idols.



**The colour shelf:** A palette of natural dye sources and products decorated with biodegradable paints at PJTSAU's Natural Dye Processing and Incubation Centre, Hyderabad.



**Hands at work:** An artisan applies an orange-yellow coat of paint to a clay Ganesha idol at the PJTSAU centre.

# Keep calm and colour on

The Natural Dye Processing and Incubation Centre is developing biodegradable paints and colours from natural dyes as safer alternatives to synthetic dyes



**Nagara Gopal**  
nagara.gopal  
@thehindu.co.in

Natural dyes are gaining renewed attention following the worldwide ban on the use of synthetic dyes. The natural dye industry had nearly vanished by the middle of the 19th century and since then has remained only in a few pockets across select States in the country. The use of synthetic dyes is associated with high environmental pollution and health risks for those handling harmful substances. As awareness of these risks grows, consumers are increasingly shifting towards natural products.

The demand for research in the natural dye industry led to the setting up of the country's premier research institute on dyes – the Natural Dye Processing and Incubation Centre (NDPIC), under the Professor Jayashankar Telangana Agricultural University (PJTSAU) – to come up in Hyderabad.

In 2016, the Telangana State Pollution Control Board (TSPCB) sponsored a project titled "Biodegradable ecopaint production for idol painting with natural dyes on large scale" with an outlay of ₹1 crore. The project enabled PJTSAU to establish a large-scale natural-dye paint production unit, the first of its kind in India, with a production capacity of two tonnes of paint a day.

The same premises also house the production of another promising technology developed by

PJTSAU – 'Eco-Holi' powders. The technologies for Eco Paints for Clay Ganesha idols and Eco-Holi powders were developed by the College of Home Science, Hyderabad.

An incubation unit here also helps weavers, artisans and entrepreneurs by providing training and access to its facilities for production and pilot-scale development of new products.

**Festival fun**

The 'ecopaint' production seeks to provide a safer alternative to synthetic colours used to paint Ganesha idols during festivals.

When the idols are immersed in water bodies at the end of the festivities, the biodegradable paint does not have a negative impact as the synthetic dyes, which may contain toxic substances, including heavy metals such as mercury, cadmium and lead. These heavy metals have a devastating impact on human health when they enter water bodies.

Similarly, the eco-friendly Holi powders are also made keeping health and safety in mind.

The goal, therefore, is to ensure that faith and celebration do not come at the cost of the environment and health. Natural dyes and biodegradable colours offer a way to reduce the environmental impact of idol painting while retaining the vibrancy associated with the festival.



**Step by step:** Natural dye is extracted from boiled sappan heartwood and used as a colouring agent in paint-making.





**Against the rules:** An artisan from Bihar works on a large Plaster of Paris (PoP) Maha Ganapati idol at a famous idol-making unit in Dhoolpet, Hyderabad. Despite repeated Telangana High Court directives to use eco-friendly clay, many artisans continue crafting of PoP idols due to high demand.



**From lab to craft:** An artisan preparing the paint to load the spray gun and paint the idol.



**Final strokes:** A student and a staff member apply the finishing touches on a clay Ganesha idol.



**Ready in colour:** An artisan prepares natural-dye paint.



**Brushwork begins:** An artisan hard at work on the Ganesha idols.



**Ready to go:** Finished clay Ganesha idols await packing to be despatched for sale.